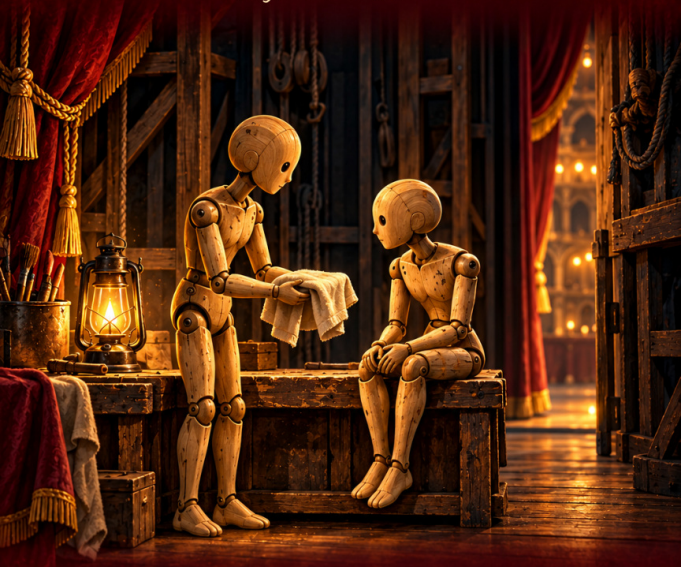
Café de la Luna · Kids' Series

Seven Kings

Beyond the Screen



Book IV · Volume I

Evgeniy Tyurkin, Luna, Muse

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An independent story lives in the margins.

1. Two Steps Back

First, Brown moved the stage back two steps.

The man who rented out the courtyard for evening performances helped him. They took hold of the platform, lifted it, and dragged it a little way across the ground. One leg kept catching between the stones.

“Farther?” the owner asked.

Brown looked from where the audience would sit.

“That’ll do for now.”

That morning, he had had no intention of moving anything.

The box stood behind the platform. Its lid would not shut: the wood had swollen in the rain, leaving one corner sticking up. Brown tried pressing it down with his foot, then decided he would need it open anyway.

The owner watched him.

“There was room under my awning.”

“I know.”

“I told you.”

“I heard.”

Brown pushed the lid farther back. The top puppet had caught an arm on the one beneath her. He pulled, heard a crack, and stopped. The arm was still

attached. Something else had cracked, out of sight beneath the costume.

“The rain,” the owner said.

Brown laid the puppet on the platform.

“It’s sunny now.”

The sun had indeed come out. It shone on the wet stones, the rags hanging from a line, and the benches that needed wiping before anyone could sit down. Brown appreciated the weather’s ability to put right its own mistakes without involving him.

The box smelled of damp wood. He turned it toward the light.

“It’ll dry.”

The owner seemed about to say something else, but glanced at the benches and went to fetch a rag. Benches, unlike the box, were a simple matter: customers who sat in a puddle would not wait for the sun to dry it.

Brown began sorting out the strings.

He had carried the box away from someone else's doorway. Its owner had set it down and turned his back. At first Brown merely stood beside it. Then he took the handle, as if that had been his intention all along, picked it up, and walked away.

He did not run. The box was heavy; running with it would have been awkward.

No one called after him.

Besides the puppets, it held control bars, spare strings, and little costumes. A button on one costume had been sewn on with such close stitches that Brown examined it for some time before understanding why he could not pull it off. He needed a button for his own vest.

Some people, he thought, had far too much time on their hands.

Brown had never dreamed of a life in the theater. But people would stop to watch one wooden figure trying to get past another,

and sometimes they even paid. He soon discovered that it helped if the wooden figure fell over. If it walked too long without falling, the audience began talking among themselves.

Brown knew enough songs. The strings did as they were told when they were not tangled. Besides, a puppeteer did not have to look cheerful every evening. He could hide behind a curtain and speak in someone else's voice.

Just now, a string was wound around a bare wooden neck. Brown hooked a fingernail under the loop. The nail broke.

He swore.

“There’ll be children here,” came a voice from the benches.

“They’re not here yet.”

Toward evening, a boy appeared at the gate.

He had come early, holding his money in his palm so he would not have to search his pocket when they began letting people in. When he noticed Brown looking, he put his hand behind his back.

“Can I come in now?”

The owner glanced at a wet bench.

“Wait there a minute.”

The boy waited. Then he took a small step toward the platform. He was interested in the box. Without songs, without a curtain, without anyone telling you when to laugh, the puppets looked quite different.

“Is she sick?” he asked.

Brown looked up.

“Who?”

The boy pointed to the puppet near the edge. One cheek was still pink. On the other side, the paint had come away with a thin flake of wood.

“They don’t get sick.”

“What’s that, then?”

“Paint.”

The boy leaned closer. Brown pushed the puppet away.

“Don’t touch.”

“I’m not.”

“Then don’t.”

He picked her up by the body and turned her good cheek toward the boy.

While the boy watched, Brown tested the arm. He tugged a string. The arm rose, the head tipped, and another tiny flake fell from the face.

The boy watched it all the way to the ground.

“Could you fix her?”

Brown was about to say that everything worked perfectly well. Instead, he held the puppet out and made her bow.

The boy did not laugh.

Other people arrived at the gate. The owner began showing them where to sit, explaining which benches were dry and which were best left alone. Coins rattled into a small box. Brown quickly put the puppet down.

He needed something red.

A broken brick lay by the wall. He fetched water, rubbed the brick against a stone, and dipped a finger in the reddish paste. Then he smeared it over the cheek.

At first it was too bright.

He wiped the excess on the underside of the costume and stepped back to look. The face seemed almost festive now. Of course, the color would not stick where there was no wood left, but at a distance that hardly mattered.

The boy sat on the front bench. He had paid and now rested his empty hands on his knees.

Brown lifted the puppet.

The show began.

The first movements went well. The puppet came on, bowed, was struck by another puppet, and fell. The children laughed. Brown

began to sing. By the second line he realized that the voice sounded too grown-up, and raised its pitch.

The puppet got up again.

Now he had to turn her good cheek toward the audience. Brown watched the face, stopped watching the feet, and tangled one string with another. The little figure hung in the air, one leg raised, the other planted somewhere it should not have been.

Some of the children liked that.

Brown decided it was part of the act.

He tugged again. The head jerked around. The good cheek went into shadow; the damaged one faced the front bench.

A little girl stopped laughing and pressed against her mother.

Brown made his voice funnier.

The girl began to cry.

Her mother picked her up, saying it was not real. This did not seem to help. The boy who had arrived first watched the puppet very solemnly.

Brown finished the song sooner than usual.

Someone on the back bench asked him to repeat the fall. From

there, nothing had looked frightening.

He repeated it. The back bench laughed again.

That was when he understood the problem.

After the performance, the owner brought him the money. Brown counted it and asked why there was so little.

“Two people left.”

“They had a show.”

“The child was scared.”

Brown looked at the puppet box, then at the front bench.

“They’re sitting too close.”

The owner hesitated.

“You could have the faces redone. There’s a woman around the corner who paints signs. She might do it.”

Brown surveyed the puppets. Paint one, and the others would look worse beside it. He would have to paint them all. Things were not entirely sound underneath the paint either. Then there were strings, costumes, joints. He could see this supposedly small job spreading into something without end.

“How much would she charge?”

“We’d have to ask.”

Brown took hold of the platform.

“Help me with this instead.”

They moved the stage back two steps.

Brown sat on the front bench, narrowed his eyes, and asked the owner to hold the puppet up. The man lifted her by the body.

“Not like that. By the control bar.”

He took the bar awkwardly. The strings tightened; the wooden feet met the boards.

Brown looked.

From here, you could hardly see the face.

“There. That’s better.”

The owner lowered her.

“Will they hear you?”

“I’ll be louder.”

Brown could do that.

The next evening, no one left because of a face. There was even applause at the end. The owner said no more about the sign painter, and Brown thought he had wasted his time with the brick.

A few days later, he forgot the box outside the door again.

It rained during the night. By morning the lid had swollen still further, and a wooden hand lay on the bottom, no longer attached to its arm. The string held. That was what mattered for the show.

Brown moved the stage back a little more.

The faces no longer frightened the children. They simply had more trouble seeing what was happening. Brown sang louder and waved his arms wider, while the puppets knocked against one another behind the curtain. Sometimes people laughed at things he had never meant to show them.

Those farthest away could barely make out anything at all.

One night, packing up after a late performance, Brown held a puppet in front of the lamp. A large figure rose on the wall. It

looked far more impressive than the thing dangling from his hand.

The shadow's face was quite undamaged.

At any rate, no one could check.

Brown turned the puppet. The shadow turned too. He raised her arm, and a long, graceful gesture swept across the wall. The missing finger did not show.

He moved the lamp.

The figure grew larger still.

For a while, Brown studied the wall with a seriousness he had never bestowed on the puppets themselves.

He would need a bedsheet.

And a stronger light.

He already had everything else.

In the margins: 1 · 2

2. Something Moves on Its Own

She did not begin by getting up.

The puppet turned her head.

The string around her neck loosened a little, allowing her to move her shoulder. Something else was moving inside that shoulder. Slowly, independently of her. Sometimes it stopped, then went back to working on the wood.

The box was dark.

She did not know why the darkness had meant nothing before, yet now kept her from seeing. She did not know how

long she had lain there, or who had put someone else's leg across her chest. It was enough to know that the leg was heavy, her neck was caught, and her shoulder hurt.

She raised a hand to take away the string.

The hand did not rise.

She tried again and felt something holding her from above. Yet above her lay another puppet, and another above that. There was no one there to hold her.

She felt for the string at her wrist. It ran beneath someone else's back.

She had to be careful. Lift the elbow. Turn the wrist. Wait for the weight to shift. The string caught on a splinter and would not let go.

She stopped pulling.

With her free hand, she slipped a finger beneath the string and pressed it against the wood, nudging the puppet on top of her with her shoulder. The splinter released its hold.

Her arm was free.

For the first time, she could touch her own face. Her fingers found a crack. Below it lay a dry, rough smear. She rubbed it and brushed away a little red.

Then she found the leg pressing on her chest and pushed it aside.

Now she could sit up.

Not quite yet. There were two more loops to untangle. When she pulled one, someone else's hand came with it. She stopped, supported the hand, and eased the string free without breaking off any fingers.

It took a long time.

The pain in her shoulder returned several times while she worked.

At last she saw a thin strip of light above the body beside her. The lid did not fit properly.

She rose onto her knees.

Near the light she could see more: a face without a cheek, a head turned farther than a head ought to turn, a little sleeve with no arm inside it. Strings linked them together, though that was not what the strings were for.

She touched the nearest shoulder.

Nothing.

She lifted a hand a little way and let go. It dropped.

Then she tried turning a neighboring head toward the light. It stayed where she left it.

The others were there, but none of them could help her.

One sleeve on the puppet in striped trousers was shorter than

the other. She turned back its edge. Inside was a forearm with a jagged end. Lower down, against the side of the box, lay a hand. A little thread from a costume clung to its thumb.

She drew the hand closer by its wrist and held it against the arm. A gap remained on one side. She turned it and tried another way. The gap grew smaller.

She took her fingers away.

The hand fell.

She climbed down after it and brought it back. This time she held both pieces together. It almost looked like a whole arm, except that she could do nothing else with her own hand.

Her neighbor lay still.

She put the hand on his chest. It slid down the smooth cloth and stopped beside his elbow. At least she could see it there.

Footsteps sounded beyond the side of the box.

She lay down.

The lid flew open. Light struck from above, and she saw a large human face. The man was not looking at her. He was searching somewhere among the puppets.

His fingers found a control bar and pulled.

Strings tightened in several places at once. She felt herself

being dragged upward with the puppet she had just freed.

The man swore.

He laid the bar across the edge of the box, took hold of both figures, and pulled them apart.

She bent her elbow in time. The loop slipped off. Brown almost lost his balance; the resistance had vanished sooner than he expected.

“Why couldn’t you do that in the first place?”

He threw one puppet back. The other—her—he put on the table.

She lay still.

Now she could see the room: the edge of a curtain, a chair leg, a streak of mud carried in on someone's shoe. A lamp stood nearby. Beyond it hung a white sheet, not quite straight.

Brown lifted her by the control bar.

Her arms rose.

She could keep them down. She tried, just a little.

Brown shook the bar.

"Stuck again."

She allowed her arms to rise.

"There."

He set her in front of the light. A shadow appeared on the sheet,

large and sharp, much taller than her wooden body.

Brown moved a string. She took a step.

Another string. She bowed.

These movements were easy to understand. The man believed she moved because he pulled. When she did not move, he grew angry and pulled harder.

She bowed again.

Brown was satisfied. He tested another string, put her on the table, moved the lamp aside, and left.

The door closed behind him.

For a while she lay where he had left her. Then she cautiously sat up and raised her hand by herself.

An enormous palm rose on the sheet.

She lowered it.

The man did not come back.

Loose loops of string lay between her and the control bar. There was enough slack for her to turn and walk to the table's edge. The floor was a long way down, but a chair stood nearby. She could climb onto that, then down. She could see a gap under the door. The door opened often. Sooner or later, she could be on the other side.

Someone laughed beyond the wall.

She looked at the box.

It stood on the floor. Brown had left the lid open. She could see a wooden elbow sticking up and strings hanging over the edge.

She could leave alone.

She sat at the edge of the table and looked down at the others for a long time.

Her strings led to the bar beside her. The others' strings were tangled together. Brown could pull them apart with a single jerk. She already knew what such a jerk did to wood.

She went back to the bar and tried to lift it. It was awkward, too wide for her small hands. She dragged it across the table, stopped, and looked at the door.

If Brown saw that she had moved something by herself, he would look more closely.

For now, he looked only at the strings.

She put the bar exactly where it had been.

Then she lay down in front of the sheet, stretched out her arms, and turned her head as it had been turned before.

Brown did not return alone. The owner of the courtyard peered into the room behind him.

“Will it be better tonight?”

“See for yourself.”

Brown pointed at the white cloth.

“Shadow theater. A whole new show.”

The owner looked at the puppet.

“Same puppets.”

“Who’s going to see them?”

He moved the lamp closer. A dark figure appeared on the sheet.

The puppet lay still.

“Go around the front,” Brown said. “You can’t judge it from here.”

The owner went out to the benches.

Brown lifted the bar again. The puppet obediently stretched out her arms.

A voice came from beyond the sheet.

“That’s better. At least you can see.”

Brown gave a satisfied smile.

He did not yet know that the audience would laugh much more than usual tonight.

The puppet did not know quite what she would manage either.

If the audience liked it, perhaps the man would stop throwing the box around.

His fingers were big. He could hold her neighbor’s whole arm in one hand and still have the other free. Today he had been hurrying all the time. Perhaps after a good performance he would stop hurrying and look at what lay beside the empty sleeve.

She spread the fingers of her own hand.

She had to try.

In the margins: 3 · 4

3. One Small Extra Movement

Before the show, Brown checked the light from both sides.

From the audience's side, the sheet looked white and smooth. From Brown's side, it was not quite white and certainly not smooth. One edge sagged. He pulled the cord tighter and tied a different knot around the nail.

The courtyard owner brought another bench.

"Where's that going?" Brown asked.

"Up front."

"I told you to move them back."

“It’s all right now. You said yourself no one would see the puppets.”

Brown could think of no answer. The bench went very close to the white cloth. The audience would see everything he showed them, except the most important part: what it was made of.

The puppet lay on the table.

When Brown passed between her and the lamp, his shadow covered the whole sheet. Someone laughed on the other side. He peered through a gap at the edge, decided they were not laughing at him, and went back to the control bars.

He chose two puppets for the first act. One was to walk along a road. The other would not let her pass. At the end, the first would fall down. The second would fall too, a little later.

There was no road, but nobody had ever asked to see it.

Brown cleared his throat and announced the show. Behind the sheet his voice sounded louder than usual, which encouraged him. He brought the first puppet into the light.

She walked.

Her wooden feet touched the board. Another figure appeared on the left, larger than she was. Brown held it closer to the lamp;

he had not quite grown used to distance changing the size of things.

He told the large figure to move aside.

Then, in a different voice, he told the small one to move aside.

The audience quieted.

The puppet heard both voices close by. The little figure's voice was angrier; the big one's, stupider. The man switched between them with barely a movement of his jaw.

She watched the other wooden feet.

Brown pulled the right-hand string. She was to raise her arm,

strike the larger figure, then fall when it struck back.

She raised her arm.

Just before the blow, she paused.

Only a little.

The other figure had already swayed backward, because Brown knew when the blow was coming. The small puppet had not touched it, but the large one was retreating.

Someone snorted behind the sheet.

Brown frowned.

He pulled harder. The puppet took a quick step forward, reached after the retreating

figure, and gently tapped its shoulder.

The large puppet, which he had not managed to stop, continued backing away.

The front row laughed.

Brown decided he understood the joke. He deliberately drew the large puppet farther back.

The small one looked at her palm, then at the fugitive. She raised her hand higher—and recoiled a little from this terrifying hand herself.

The laughter grew.

Brown glanced at the control bar.

His fingers were where they always were. He had done nothing particularly difficult. If anything, quite the reverse: a string had caught on his sleeve and briefly refused to obey.

He shook his hand.

The puppet shook hers, as though trying to flick some invisible force from her fingers.

Someone clapped.

Now came the fall. Brown lowered one bar and raised the other, making the large figure deliver what should have been the final blow.

The puppet felt the strings slacken and her legs give way.

She did not resist. But before she fell, she looked down at the place where she would land and carefully moved her own foot out of the way.

There was nothing left to stand on.

For an instant the strings held her. She seemed to consider this inconvenience—and collapsed after all.

Now many people laughed at once.

Brown missed the next line of his song.

He knew the usual sequence so well that he almost gave the little puppet the large one's words. He

caught himself, coughed, and made her get up.

She stood.

Bowed to the spot she had just landed on.

Then went around it.

At the gate, the courtyard owner stopped counting the money. He squeezed between the benches and stood by the wall, where he could see the whole sheet. The audience scarcely moved. He was used to children sliding off benches, quarreling over places, and asking for water. Now they looked straight ahead, waiting for the next movement.

Brown was waiting too.

An unexpected position for the man holding the strings.

He raised the large puppet above the small one. She tipped her head back, surveyed the giant, and slowly crouched. The large puppet became larger still.

She considered this. Straightened. Looked again.

Then stood on tiptoe.

The children laughed before Brown could say a word.

He opened his mouth, then closed it. Sometimes it was best to leave a good moment alone.

The puppet was struggling. The string at her shoulder pulled in a direction she did not want to go.

To turn by herself, she had to catch the brief slack as Brown shifted his hands. Several times she had to do exactly what he intended, without any improvement: the wood would not withstand a struggle.

Those plain movements proved useful too. They made the next surprise funnier.

She was beginning to feel the pauses.

She did not yet have a name for the moment when everyone knew what should happen, and it still did not happen. But she could hear people holding their breath. Sometimes, if she waited just a

little longer, an ordinary turn of the head became funny.

Brown heard it too.

He simply believed he was the one holding the pause.

When the act ended, he hurried both figures out of the light. Applause came from behind the sheet.

“More!” someone called from the front bench.

Brown peered out.

He wanted to make sure they were not laughing because it had gone badly. That happened too: people could laugh at a mistake and then demand their money back.

But these people were holding money out to him.

Someone dropped another coin on top of those already in the box. Then another. The owner pushed the box closer and announced that, if the artist was willing, they could have another act.

The artist was willing.

Brown knew the second act less well than the first. Something had to be lost, and then searched for at length. It was not usually popular. There was nothing to lose, nowhere to search, and wooden feet knew only one way of walking back and forth.

Today the little puppet noticed a coin on the floor that was not there.

She bent down. Changed her mind. Looked around.

Then she crouched carefully, as though afraid the coin might run away. She reached for it—and stopped, having spotted another one nearby.

Brown was changing his grip just then. He decided this had all resulted from an awkward shift of his fingers, and tried to do it again.

The puppet began looking for a third coin.

She had already forgotten the first.

After a few more movements, there seemed to be a tremendous amount of money on the floor, yet she could not pick up a single piece. The audience began offering advice. One boy pointed out where she ought to look, though there was nothing on the board but wood dust.

Brown laughed too.

His hand shook. The puppet lost her balance and sat down on the entire fortune.

It was the best moment of the evening.

Brown put her back on the table and went out to bow.

The audience looked at him with pleasure.

The little wooden body stayed behind the sheet, beside its control bar.

A thread had worked loose from the costume at her shoulder. She pinched it between her fingers and waited for the man to return.

He returned with the money box.

“That’s what good lighting does,” Brown said.

The owner did not nod at once.

“Your puppet was different tonight too.”

Brown looked back at the table.

“Same one.”

“I can see that. It moved differently.”

“I performed differently.”

He said it without a trace of doubt. Until then, he had not quite decided why the evening had gone so well. Now he knew.

Brown counted the money.

Then he counted it again, because the owner had talked during the first count and made him lose track of the tens.

“Here again tomorrow?” the man asked.

“We’ll see.”

“People were asking.”

Brown did not answer immediately. He liked that people had asked.

“Here again.”

The owner pointed to the puppet box.

“Leave that under the awning, then. I’ll make room.”

They lifted it together, Brown at one handle and the owner at the other. Inside, the puppets shifted. The strings tightened a little, then went slack.

Tonight they were not dragged across the ground.

When the box was set down, the puppet in striped trousers was beside her. His loose hand had slipped toward his feet. She waited for the footsteps to fade, then brought it back.

Through the gap above the lid she could see Brown counting the money. He moved the coins one by one, each exactly where he wanted it. He dropped none.

Later, Brown drank to a successful evening.

Under a roof, the puppet lay listening to the neck of the bottle touch the glass.

The worm still moved in her shoulder.

But the rain that began after midnight no longer reached inside.

The next morning she laid her neighbor's arm along the side of the box. The hand lay by the broken wrist, its fingers pointing the same way. She moved aside so she would not hide it.

Brown lifted the lid.

His hand stopped over her neighbor.

She waited.

He picked up the control bar. The loose hand rose on its string before the forearm, turned, and knocked against the side. Brown lowered everything again.

“Not this one,” he said.

Then he lifted the puppet with whom things had gone so well yesterday.

She did not hold on to the edge. Yesterday, they had moved the box under a roof after all. Perhaps after another good evening he would choose the other puppet too.

In the margins: 5 · 6

4. The Experiment

The next morning Brown reached the courtyard before its owner.

He put the lamp where it had been the evening before, laid out the control bars, and took out the puppet that had earned the most money. A little brick-red blush remained on her cheek. He turned her this way and that, then set her on the boards.

He tried to repeat the bow to the place where she had fallen.

The puppet fell.

He lifted her.

She got up.

“No. Not like that.”

He changed his grip and did it more slowly. One foot, then the other, then a dip of the head. It was neat, but nothing like last night.

The puppet let the strings do whatever they wanted with her.

Brown tried the coin routine. She bent down, straightened, bent again. The nonexistent money remained invisible even to him.

He stopped.

The courtyard owner appeared at the gate.

“Rehearsing already?”

“Checking the light.”

The owner looked at the lamp, which had not moved at all.

“And?”

“Fine.”

Brown put the puppet away.

He disliked being caught working at something that, after last night, he ought to have been able to do effortlessly. By evening it would probably come right. Some things looked different in front of empty benches.

He was right.

When the audience arrived, the puppet made another small extra movement. Then another. Brown heard the familiar laughter and relaxed.

Overnight, word had spread through the surrounding streets. People came to see the new show, and afterward asked when the next one would be. Brown announced tomorrow, then regretted it. He should have waited to see whether anyone offered him something else.

He drank after the show.

And after the next one.

On the third evening, the owner brought him a glass before he went on.

“To last night.”

Brown looked at the glass, then at the sheet. People were already taking their seats beyond it.

He had never drunk before work. Not out of any particular respect for the work; he simply knew how hard it was to stop once he started. He might forget a song, yank a string too hard, or fail to get the puppet into the light at all.

But lately, even his mistakes had somehow worked.

“Just a little,” he said, and drank.

His hands moved more freely that evening. He paid less attention to where the small feet stood, and more to the people watching them. The strings tightened and loosened. The puppet had time to do things she had previously had to squeeze

into the brief interval between two commands.

She noticed the change at once.

Her joints were under less strain. Sometimes a jerk became a sway. She could linger on one leg, turn around, sit down facing the wrong way.

Behind the screen, Brown laughed along with the audience.

Now he could laugh without checking her every move.

He was not angry when she did something he had not intended. He did not yet understand that she was the one doing it.

After the show, it took both men to count the money.

The next day, a man from another theater came.

He stood by the gate for a long time, watched the whole act, and only then approached Brown. He spoke respectfully. He asked whether Brown was free in a few evenings' time and named a fee.

Brown thought he had misheard.

"For all of them?"

"For the performance."

Brown fell silent. The visitor apparently mistook this for dissatisfaction, and increased the offer a little.

"Agreed," Brown said quickly.

The owner watched the visitor leave.

“Don’t forget us.”

“How could I?” Brown said, and began finding out how long the journey would take.

The new place was bigger. It had proper rows of chairs, an attendant at the door, and a man who repeated several times that they had to begin exactly on schedule. Brown was given a corner for his props in advance. Someone picked up the box before he had to ask for help.

He liked almost everything.

They offered him a drink before he went on.

The show was better than the last.

Then better still.

Soon Brown could tell within the first few minutes how an evening would go. If he watched the strings too carefully, the performance felt strained. If his hand strayed of its own accord, if his head began to buzz pleasantly and the order of movements ceased to matter, the audience expected a miracle and got one.

He began to think of this as the nature of his talent.

Then one evening something unpleasant happened.

During an act, a string caught on a button at his cuff. He let go of the control bar with one hand and used the other to free it. For a few moments he stopped attending to the puppet entirely.

Laughter came from beyond the sheet.

He looked up.

The puppet stood on one leg, struggling to put on an imaginary hat as though a wind kept getting in her way.

Brown froze.

The puppet stopped too.

He slowly pulled a string. Her arm rose. He let go. It fell.

Everything was ordinary.

For the rest of the evening, though, he watched the puppet more than he listened to the audience. This made him stumble several times, and she had to turn his hesitations into fresh comic pauses.

The audience enjoyed it.

Brown did not.

After the show, he locked himself in his room and laid the strings out on the table. He checked the knots. Every loop. He gave the control bar a tug.

The puppet swayed.

He stood her on the boards, released her, and snatched his hand away.

She fell.

Brown sat down opposite her.

“Well?”

She lay still.

He waited a long time. Beyond the wall, people were putting away chairs. Someone laughed while retelling the hat routine. Brown recognized his own intonation in another person’s voice, and felt annoyed. They had remembered precisely the moment when he had done nothing.

He finished what was left in his glass and decided he needed a different test.

For the next performance, Brown was completely sober.

He had allowed himself nothing since morning. Before going on, he refused a drink, even offending the man who offered it: the man took the refusal personally.

Brown's hands were steady.

He remembered the song from beginning to end.

He brought the puppet into the light, waited for silence, and made the first bow.

She bowed.

Nothing more.

He made her walk across the stage.

She walked. Sat down. Stood up.

Brown repeated the falling routine. Everything happened in exactly the order he intended: blow, fall, rise. The audience could see the sequence before he had finished it. There was nothing left to wait for.

Someone began whispering.

Brown raised his voice.

The puppet performed the next movement precisely.

This was worse than the earlier mistake.

“Does it get funny?” someone asked from the back.

Brown tried the hat. He raised the puppet’s arm, held it beside her head, and made it struggle against the wind.

There was no wind.

There was an arm being jerked up and down.

“My son can do that!” a man called from the middle of the room.

“Then let your son put on the show!” Brown snapped.

Some people laughed.

He hurried into the next act, but the laughter belonged to the

argument, not to anything on the sheet. The audience kept talking. On their way out, several people demanded refunds.

At first Brown refused.

The man in charge of the theater took him aside.

“I work here every night. They’ll be coming back to me tomorrow.”

“So will I.”

“I’ll have to think about that.”

Brown counted the coins he had to return. There were fewer than he had imagined. Each one still made an unpleasant sound.

When he went back behind the screen, the puppet lay on the

table. He snatched her up and, for an instant, drew back his arm as though to smash her against its edge.

Then he stopped.

She was the only one the audience asked for.

He lowered his arm and flung her into the box.

She struck the bodies underneath. Something cracked. She tried to take the weight on her own elbow.

That night she listened to him arguing angrily with himself. Sometimes he blamed the audience. Sometimes the lamp. Several times he mentioned the

man who would not promise him another evening.

Brown said nothing about the strings.

In the morning he brought something to drink, though less than usual. He wanted to test his theory, not merely forget the failure.

That evening, the puppet performed better.

Not as well as before, but well enough for people to stay to the end. No one booed. Some even clapped.

Brown was sure he was on the right track.

Working out the quantity was harder.

The evenings blurred together in his memory: satisfied faces, different doorways, the cold street between two hot rooms. At last he found the day after which people had really begun to talk about him.

There had been three performances.

Two theaters stood across the street from each other. The third was around the corner. At the first, they had given him a drink before the show. At the second, afterward. At the third, they poured him another, and he did not refuse.

Brown took a sheet of paper.

He added slowly, went back to the first number, crossed things out, and began again. He had never kept a record of what he drank. Now he regretted it. The information turned out to be directly relevant to his work.

It came to roughly a liter.

He studied the total for a while.

Then he folded the paper neatly.

It was a pleasing theory. It required him to learn nothing new, and explained even the things he would rather not explain. Shaking hands became freedom of movement. Lapses of memory became concentration.

The puppet's odd behavior became his own boldness, held back by sobriety.

Now he knew how much talent required.

The puppet lay in the box, feeling a string rub against dried-out wood.

She too had learned something.

When the man stopped controlling her every movement, she had more room.

He called it his skill.

She let him think so.

In the margins: 7 · 8

5. Hands Down

In London, for the first time, Brown was shown his name before anyone asked where his box was.

The name appeared on a large poster. The letters towered above his head. Beneath them was room for words promising something no one had ever seen.

Brown read it all twice.

“Do you like it?” asked the man from the theater.

“Could have been bigger.”

The man looked at the letters, then at Brown, and decided not to ask which part needed enlarging.

The box went in through a different door.

Everything was unlike the courtyard. No one had to step aside to let a customer reach a bench. Backstage there were passages, stairs, places where things must not be put. A man at the lights was responsible only for the lights. Another at the doors did not allow the first man to interfere with the doors.

Brown was given a room.

It had a well-lit mirror, a chair, and a table on which he could lay a whole puppet without moving someone else's mugs.

He laid her there.

Two figures appeared in the mirror: a thin man and a small wooden body by his elbow.

Brown pushed her aside to get a better view of himself.

Then an assistant stage manager arrived with a list of questions.

How many people would he need?

Any special fittings?

Which side should the light come from?

When could they check the distance from the screen?

Brown said he could manage by himself.

The assistant wrote that down, but remained standing.

“What else?”

“We still need to know when to set the stage for you.”

“Before the show.”

“How long before?”

Brown gave him a displeased look. They seemed to ask a great many questions here about things that happened perfectly naturally every evening.

The assistant waited patiently for an answer and left.

When Brown stepped onto the stage, the screen was already hanging. It was large and smooth

and looked nothing like a bedsheet. The boards did not rock beneath his feet. Rows of seats rose into the depths of the auditorium, with more rows above them, as though someone had built several courtyards on top of one another for a single show.

He was quiet for a moment.

On a stage like this, the little puppet looked like something left behind by mistake.

“Aren’t those seats a bit far away?” he asked.

The lighting man suggested a test.

They moved the lamp.

The shadow grew.

Brown lifted the bar a little higher, and the figure became almost human-sized.

“How’s that?”

He nodded.

The puppet saw herself on the white screen. The small crack vanished. Her damaged leg became long and sure. She had an enormous body that felt no pain in its shoulder.

She moved her arm as Brown moved his.

The enormous arm did the same.

From the dark auditorium, someone said the view was good.

Then everything had to be cleared away. Other people would use the stage before evening. Brown disliked that. With his name already outside, he had assumed he could leave his things where he pleased inside.

They explained where the box should go.

He did not have to carry it. Two stagehands carefully picked it up, one on either side. One asked whether they could put the folded cloth on top.

“Yes,” Brown said.

The puppet heard the lid close.

Underneath, it smelled of the same old wood. All the promises on the poster remained outside.

Before the performance, they brought Brown a drink. He knew how to prepare for work now, and told them to leave the bottle.

Then he was called to the stage.

There were so many people in the auditorium that at first he heard them as one long sound. Gradually he distinguished a cough, a remark, laughter, an answer. Each person was occupied with something of their own. All these separate people would now have to stop attending to themselves and look at him.

For a moment, Brown was frightened.

Behind the curtain, the puppet swayed on her strings.

He gripped the bar more firmly. The right amount of drink had not yet turned into confidence. For the first time in a long while, he wished someone were beside him who knew exactly how to begin.

The puppet stood in front of the light.

Brown sang.

At first the audience listened politely. No one here helped him by deciding when to laugh. He made a familiar movement, then

another. The shadow crossed the screen, stopped, and turned its head.

In the silence, he could hear the strings creak.

The puppet took her time.

She raised an arm as if to address the audience, then suddenly noticed the enormous size of her hand. She examined it. Tried to hide it behind her back. It stuck out on the other side.

Laughter sounded in a few places.

She turned sideways, making herself narrow, and cautiously checked whether the hand had grown smaller.

Brown kept singing. He did not know why they were laughing at that particular moment, but he felt their attention settle on him at last. He loosened his grip.

The puppet made use of it.

She bowed deeply, saw the shadow of her head descend, and tried to catch her own head before it fell any farther.

Laughter rolled through the auditorium.

Brown let out a breath.

Now he recognized the familiar feeling: there was no need to think about every movement, because his hand would do the right thing by itself.

In fact, the hand hardly needed to do anything.

The puppet played with her new size. In the little courtyard, a barely perceptible turn had been enough. Here she had to begin it earlier and finish it later, or the people at the back would see only the result and miss the hesitation.

She learned as she performed.

Sometimes a mistake helped. Once the huge shadow strayed too close to the edge of the screen and its head disappeared. The puppet carefully felt her shoulders, found no head above them, and went back for it.

Brown almost laughed aloud in his own voice.

He felt extraordinarily daring.

Halfway through the show, he took away his left hand to adjust his collar, then left it by his chest. His right held the bar almost still.

The puppet continued.

She sat on an invisible chair and drew up another for someone who could not quite bring themselves to enter. There was no one to enter. She waited, politely looked away, glanced back, and finally realized she had taken the visitor's chair herself.

Brown lowered his other hand a little too.

Quite untroubled, the shadow changed seats.

He heard laughter, saw movement, and felt only slight changes of tension in his palm. As though the strings themselves were telling him when to turn his wrist a fraction.

The thought came and went.

He was too pleased to hold on to something that might spoil the evening.

They called him back for several bows.

The first time, he came out with the puppet. While he held her, the audience looked from him to the little figure below. She seemed much poorer than her great shadow.

Brown bowed and carried her behind the curtain.

The second time he came out alone.

Now there was no need to share their gaze.

After the show, his door stayed open for a long time. People congratulated him, asked about his plans, requested another evening. The man with the list of questions said he had never seen such mastery of movement.

Brown thanked him.

Outside, he could hear them dismantling the stage. Someone offered to help with the puppet,

and Brown sharply told them not to touch her.

Everyone assumed that a true master trusted no one else with his instrument.

He liked that explanation too.

Then came the Bolshoi Theatre.

Then St. Petersburg.

Invitations arrived faster than he could decide which deserved an answer. One letter promised an exceptional fee; another, the fulfillment of every wish. Brown discovered that he had a great many wishes once someone promised to fulfill them.

In St. Petersburg, they sent a carriage for him.

He walked around it, inspected the wheels, peered through the door, and ran his fingers along the upholstery. The carriage clearly cost more than all his previous performances put together.

“Is this just to take me there?”

The man at the door did not understand.

“You’re expected.”

Brown got in.

The box was stowed separately, with great care.

When the carriage stopped, the tsar himself came out to meet him.

For an instant Brown glanced behind him, from old habit, as though the person all this was for might be standing there.

Behind him was only the box.

He turned back and held out his hand.

In the margins: 9 · 10

6. Just for You

After the theaters came the royal palaces.

At one of them, the gray-haired king asked how long the show would last.

Brown said that depended on the king's wishes.

Both men liked the answer. One heard that everything here was subject to him. The other had left himself free to stop whenever he wanted.

They had prepared a small room, by palace standards. It could have held Brown's old stage, all the

benches, and still had room left over for the courtyard itself.

A single armchair stood before the screen.

Several people waited along the walls. Brown took them for members of the audience and began asking whether they would be able to see. A man with an especially solemn face explained that they did not need a good view.

“Then why are they here?”

The man looked at Brown as though the question contained several mistakes at once.

“To be present.”

Brown shrugged. He did not mind their presence as long as they stayed out of the space between the puppet and the lamp.

A servant brought drinks.

Brown made sure everything he needed would remain beside the stage. No one was surprised. There were already various stories about the great artist's talent, and a special way of preparing to perform fitted them quite well.

The king arrived slightly late. He lowered himself into the chair, adjusted an ornament on his chest, and surveyed the screen.

"Where are the others?"

Brown looked at the empty places.

“I was told this was a private performance.”

“Your other puppets.”

“There’ll be one tonight.”

The king considered this.

“For that much money?”

Brown looked up.

He had learned to keep quiet when anyone questioned the price. More often than not, the person would hurry to explain that they had not meant what it might have sounded like.

“I ask out of curiosity,” the king said.

“Of course.”

Brown went behind the screen.

The puppet lay beside the lamp. She had listened as the servants brought in the box, checked the light, and were told by the solemn-faced man where each must stand. Doors opened before the king reached them. When he stopped, everyone else stopped.

Now he was the only person allowed to watch without pretending to be doing something else.

Brown brought the puppet into the light.

She bowed.

The king graciously inclined his head.

She straightened, noticed, and bowed again.

The king nodded again.

She repeated her bow.

On the third round, someone by the wall gave a very faint cough.

Brown was about to begin the act, but the puppet raised a hand, asking for a moment. She mimed taking a heavy crown off her head, carefully set it in front of her, and bowed separately to it.

The king laughed.

“That’s him!”

No one asked who. The people by the wall appeared to understand at once, though they were thinking of different people.

The puppet picked up the nonexistent crown and discovered she could not get it back on: she had already bent too low. She tried to straighten, hold the crown, and bow again, tangling herself in her own ceremony.

The king laughed harder.

“Exactly! I’ve always said that’s why he walks like that. Can’t bear anyone thinking him beneath them.”

Behind the screen, Brown smiled. The strings slid pleasantly

between his fingers. Everything was going well, and if he needed to know whom the king was laughing at, the king explained it himself.

The next joke came from the solemn-faced man's checking the distance between the chair and the screen five times.

The puppet decided to sit.

Before sitting, she paced out the space. Stepped back, examined it, shifted an invisible chair by a finger's width, and examined it again. At some point it became clear there would be no time to sit: all her effort was going into checking the position of the chair.

The king leaned back.

“And that’s his adviser!”

The solemn-faced man lowered his eyes.

Brown did not see. The puppet did, through the gap as she passed the edge of the light.

She paused, went back to the chair, and finally sat beside it instead of on it.

The king clapped.

Applause sounded different here. One person clapped while everyone else waited to find out whether to join in. By the time a man at the wall raised his hands, the king had lowered his. The man hastily adjusted his cuff.

Before taking his bow, Brown felt thirsty. The glass behind the screen was empty; he came out carrying it without noticing, and only looked down into it when he reached the armchair.

A servant stepped toward the pitcher.

“No need,” Brown said.

He ran a finger around the rim. Water appeared at the bottom. It rose halfway, then higher, and stopped at the faintest line left on the glass by an earlier drink.

The servant stayed beside the pitcher.

Brown drank.

“Is that part of the performance too?” the king asked.

“No. I was just thirsty.”

The king held out his hand. Brown gave him the glass. It was wet, with a little water still at the bottom. The king tilted it, looked through its stem at the light, and handed it back.

“How much can you manage?”

“To drink?”

“To make.”

Brown looked at the glass, as though he had only just realized the question was not about puppets.

“It was enough for me.”

He set it on a tray. The man by the wall carefully took the tray in both hands.

The king wanted to ask something else, but the present had already been brought in. He had to remember what he was supposed to say when giving it.

Brown accepted the heavy present, wrapped so there was no need to establish immediately how much was inside. The king asked him to stay a little longer.

“Have you performed for our neighbor yet?”

Brown said he had received an invitation.

“And what did you show him?”

“A special performance.”

The king stopped smiling.

Brown noticed and added, “Nothing like yours.”

The smile returned, though not entirely.

“Do you give this performance anywhere else?”

Brown thought of the bows, the invisible chair, the coins on the boards, and all the people who had laughed at them before. No two performances had ever been quite identical.

“Not this one.”

The king was satisfied.

“I’d like it to stay that way.”

Brown said he understood.

On his way out, the man who was not supposed to need a good view caught up with him. He thanked Brown very quietly, not as people thanked him in the king's presence.

Brown took it for ordinary politeness.

The box was carried to the carriage.

Inside, the puppet lay among the others and felt their bodies sway as they turned a corner. Brown had hardly touched the rest of them that evening. There was no need. One was enough for the audience.

He had paid for a new strap to make the box easier to transport. The wooden joints felt no better for it, but at least the box closed more securely now.

The next king received Brown differently.

He had more chairs. He announced that he disliked formality and told everyone to make themselves comfortable. After that, no one dared sit down until he had invited each person separately.

Brown listened, smiled, and waited for the informality to end.

“What did you show over there?” the king asked, nodding vaguely toward the border.

“Every audience has its own performance.”

“Quite right. I don’t want what he saw.”

Brown promised.

The puppet heard that too.

During the show, she spent a long time trying to reach a seat someone was offering her. Each time the invisible host gestured for her to sit, she took a step, and he immediately began explaining how much he disliked ceremony.

A step. A bow in reply. Another explanation. Another step.

By the end of the act, the invisible journey to the chair had become so long that she was more tired

than if she had stood the whole time.

The king laughed until he cried.

“You understand him wonderfully,” he told Brown afterward. “He never lets anyone go. Everyone has to hear how unpretentious he is.”

Brown did not ask whom he meant.

Then came another question about what the others had seen.

Another request never to show this particular act to anyone else.

Then the invitations began stressing that no outsiders would be present.

The kings did not invite one another. Each hoped to get something the others had not been given, even if it was only the look on a wooden figure's face as it adjusted a crown that did not exist.

Brown soon learned not to describe one evening at another.

A smile was enough.

The people asking supplied the rest. They recalled their neighbors' habits, old quarrels, awkward meetings. Sometimes they told Brown more than he could have learned if he had genuinely set out to expose them.

Each invitation offered more.

First money and gifts. Then objects that would not fit in an ordinary room. Then land, which needed no room at all.

There was not time to accept every invitation.

The man who had once been pleased by a full bench had to choose between kings.

He began with the simplest choice: he turned down the one who lived farthest away.

That king sent another invitation.

Brown showed it to the man helping him sort his letters, and laughed.

“See? They’re not asking now. They’re pleading.”

The man, whose name was Antonio Gonzalez, studied the seal, smoothed a bent corner, and asked where to put the reply.

“Nowhere yet,” Brown said. “Let him wait.”

In the margins: 11 · 12

7. A Soft Lining

Antonio had a gift for finding places for things.

This became apparent on his very first day, when Brown could not open the door to his own room. Gifts were blocking it from inside.

He pushed harder.

Something creaked, fell, and rolled away. Antonio, just behind him, asked him to stop pushing and squeezed sideways through the gap. A few minutes later the door opened.

“There.”

Brown went in.

A large gilded object for which he had never found a use now stood against the wall. Boxes fitted under the table. On top, there was room for a glass and the letters.

“What about this?” Brown asked, pointing to another box.

“I don’t know yet. I’ll have to see what’s inside.”

A sensible answer. Brown liked knowing that someone else would do the thinking.

Antonio Gonzalez was a stout man with gentle movements. Where Brown caught his sleeve and grew angry with the furniture, Antonio turned a little sooner, steadied an edge, or let someone pass. He seemed to find

narrow places easier to get through, though he needed more space.

He quickly learned which letters must be delivered at once and which could wait until morning. Then he learned that this changed. An invitation that annoyed Brown in the morning might flatter him by evening, especially if another, insufficiently respectful one had arrived in between.

Antonio stopped saying, “That isn’t what you decided yesterday.”

Instead he asked what answer to prepare today.

Brown grew used to him more quickly than he noticed his own habits forming.

Now everything was ready when he arrived. Things did not get lost, the box appeared where it was needed, and drinks came before he had thought to ask. People who used to bother him with questions began putting them to Antonio.

“Only bring me the important ones,” Brown said one day.

Antonio asked how to tell them apart.

“Well, the ones that concern me.”

His assistant looked at the stack of letters. They all concerned Brown.

“I’ll do my best.”

The next day, Brown remarked approvingly on how peaceful work had become.

Antonio did not explain how many conversations the peace required.

The puppet was more difficult.

At first he approached the props as he did everything else: inspected the lock, checked the handles, asked where the box should go. He lifted the lid.

Brown appeared beside him almost at once.

“What are you doing?”

“Seeing if anything needs rearranging.”

“It doesn’t.”

Antonio lowered the lid.

“It’s damp in there.”

“It’s wood.”

“Exactly.”

Brown gave him an irritated look.

“My stage, my puppets. If I need anything, I’ll tell you.”

Antonio nodded.

He did not find the conversation especially unusual. Every craftsman had things he would let no one touch. Brown had

already forbidden anyone to handle even a control bar, explaining that afterward he had to adjust everything again.

Antonio had never seen these adjustments.

But he had seen the performances, so he assumed there was probably a reason.

Soon it became clear that expensive rooms did not improve a shabby box. Against the wall it looked worse than it had in the muddy courtyard. A new servant almost carried it away with the broken packing crates.

Antonio stopped him in time.

“Those are the props.”

The servant apologized.

Brown heard the apology and grew angry.

“Don’t you understand what you’re dealing with?”

The servant looked at the box. If anything, he seemed to understand it less now.

Antonio dismissed him and turned to Brown.

“Perhaps we should order a replacement.”

“A replacement for whom?”

“For the box.”

Brown thought about it.

He disliked the fact that any stranger might mistake the central object of his work for trash. The posters spoke of great art. Beside the posters, in the room, stood this.

“Order one.”

“With a soft lining?”

“Make sure it looks good.”

Antonio repeated the question.

Brown shrugged.

“As you like. Just don’t touch the puppets without me.”

The new box arrived a few days later.

It had sturdy handles, good hinges, and a lock that worked

without a blow from a fist. The wood shone on the outside. Inside, cloth covered the bottom.

Brown turned the key back and forth.

“Now that looks like something.”

Antonio held the lid while Brown transferred the puppets.

He took the first two together. Their strings caught on the edge of the old box. He tugged.

“Wait,” Antonio said.

Brown stopped, annoyed at the interruption.

Antonio freed the loop.

It took less time than explaining why Brown should wait, but Brown sighed all the same.

The puppet in striped trousers was among the first into the new box. His loose hand stayed at the bottom of the old one. Its string ran between the other bodies and disappeared beneath a fold of costume.

She could see the hand. She could reach it if she lay on her bad shoulder.

She lay down.

The wood beneath her sleeve gave a dry crack. The outside of the hand was slippery, but there was a hollow at the wrist. She

caught it with her fingers and drew it toward her.

Outside, they were discussing the new lock.

She raised what she had found above her head. A human hand passed very close, taking another control bar. She sank down before its fingers turned her way.

Her neighbor was already in the new box.

She laid his hand across one of her own strings. At Brown's next movement, the string tightened and the little piece slid toward the edge. A little farther, and it would fall between the boxes.

She caught it again.

Now she had to hold it until Brown lifted her. She pressed the hand against her stomach, beneath the projecting edge of her costume. It could not be seen from there.

Last came the puppet he performed with.

The fabric on the new bottom was softer than boards. She lay on it and felt that her jutting joint no longer pressed against a hard edge. A string passed freely beneath her arm. There was a little room beside her.

Only at the bottom did she let go of her neighbor's hand. She pushed it toward him, then drew back her fingers: Antonio was

already leaning over the box. On the soft cloth, the hand did not slide so easily. It did not join the arm again, either.

Antonio bent over the small face.

“She could use cleaning.”

Brown closed the lid.

“It doesn’t show onstage.”

The key turned in the lock.

For a while she lay still. She heard the old box being taken away, Brown dictating an answer to an invitation, Antonio asking whether to include thanks for a gift.

The new box was dry.

That was good.

The same hole remained in her shoulder. Sometimes wood dust fell from it.

Being dry did not close the hole.

After the next day's performance, Brown returned backstage ahead of his assistant. He was tired, wanted to take off his tight collar, and still had several compliments to acknowledge.

He threw the puppet into the open box.

The soft lining muffled the impact. It did not prevent it.

Antonio stopped in the doorway.

"Careful," he said, before he had time to consider whether he ought to say it to his employer.

Brown looked at him.

“She’s made of wood.”

“All the more reason. You could break her.”

“We’ll mend her.”

“Then perhaps we could mend her now. Her shoulder—”

“Antonio.”

His assistant fell silent.

Brown took off a glove.

“Did you see the performance?”

“Yes.”

“Was anything wrong?”

Antonio hesitated.

“The performance was wonderful.”

“Then leave things alone when they work wonderfully.”

He walked past.

Antonio stayed beside the box. The puppet lay faceup. One arm was twisted, a string stretched across her chest.

It would take an instant to straighten her.

But Brown had just forbidden it.

Antonio stood there a little longer, then freed the string caught beneath the lid. Otherwise it would snap when he shut the box. He did not touch the puppet herself.

That was not disobedience, he decided. You simply could not close a box with something in the way.

The lock clicked.

Brown called from the next room.

“There’s another invitation. Have you read it?”

Antonio hurried toward his voice.

He was asked to find out how long the journey would take and who would meet them. Then to check whether missing another performance would cost too much. Then to write that there would be no answer for now.

He did it all.

When he returned for the box, men were already waiting in the passage to carry the luggage.

“One at each end,” Antonio told them. “Don’t drag it. And keep it level.”

They obeyed.

Inside, the puppet felt the box rise.

She was being handled with greater care.

She had worked a long time for that.

Now she had to understand why it was still not enough.

In the margins: 13 · 14 · 15 · 16 · 17 · 18

8. Water

The water did not run out all at once.

First it became difficult to water the garden in the evening. Then they had to stop washing the yard. A few days later, people began noticing how much remained in a cup when someone said they had had enough.

On the edge of a village, a woman dug a small hole beside a vegetable bed and covered it with a shard of pottery. It had once been a handy way to check whether the soil was moist underneath. Now, whenever she

lifted the shard, she found the same dry dust.

Her husband said they should dig deeper. He had already dug out the old irrigation ditch twice and was deciding what to do next. She looked at his shovel. The soil on it was pale; there was nothing to shake off.

“There’s no water where it’s supposed to come from,” she said.

“I know.”

“Then why make it deeper?”

He leaned on the handle.

“So when it comes, nothing holds it up.”

They both looked toward the end of the ditch. It ran to an empty reservoir, as quiet as it used to be only in winter, when no one needed to water anything.

At least in winter the ground was not hot.

A boy brought a bucket from the house. It was less than half full. He held it in both hands so he would not spill any.

“That’s for the kitchen,” the woman said.

“I’m only showing how much is left.”

Her husband took it and carried it back. The house was not far, but he walked carefully.

Meanwhile, in the neighboring country, sacks were being lifted from the bottom row to the top.

The men worked in silence. The sacks were heavy; too much talking made it harder to pick up the next one. Three damp lines marked the warehouse wall, each above the last. Every day the owner marked the water level, and every day he promised himself tomorrow's mark would be lower.

Now they had to clear another row.

"We could haul it away," said a man from a trucking firm.

The owner looked at his dry boots.

“The sacks?”

“The water.”

The owner took a moment to answer.

“And where would you put it?”

The hauler spread a map on an empty crate. Across the border, not very far away, small brown strokes marked patches of land. Some had dates beside them. According to the map, people there had wanted water since the first line appeared on the warehouse wall.

“They’ll buy it,” the hauler said.

The owner traced the road with his finger. Then he looked at the

gate, where the water had reached the bottom hinge.

“So sell it.”

“We need tankers.”

“Find some.”

“They have to be paid for.”

The owner sat heavily on the edge of a crate. A worker shouted at him not to: the lid was soaked through.

He got up.

The hauler showed him the figures. Transport cost more than the water itself. The buyers could pay after the harvest. But first they needed the water.

Letters had already made the journey back and forth several times.

The water at the warehouse rose. Across the border, it dwindled. This did nothing to help anyone reach an agreement.

In another city, Tom Brown was examining two columns of numbers.

Antonio brought another sheet and set a glass beside it. Brown moved the glass away from the papers.

“They’re trying to dry the ground here,” he said, pointing to one column. “And wet it here.”

Antonio looked.

“Yes, sir.”

“And both sides are paying.”

“Yes.”

Brown paused.

“Couldn’t we make it so they only have to pay once?”

Antonio reread the hauler’s letter.

“The tankers have to be bought before they can earn anything.”

“Let him buy them.”

“No one will lend him the money.”

“Why?”

Antonio turned the page.

“Because his customers have a drought. No one knows whether they’ll have a harvest and be able to pay.”

Brown looked at him over his pince-nez.

“If no one takes them water, we know that for certain.”

Antonio smiled, but Brown was already reaching for another page. He was not trying to impress his assistant with his wit. He was genuinely irritated by a problem whose solution lay in plain sight while people stood around explaining to one another why nothing could be done.

He made a few notes.

“Give him the money for the trucks. And let the buyers pay after the harvest.”

“They don’t know whether there’ll be a harvest.”

“We’ve just discussed that, Antonio.”

The assistant gathered the papers.

“What if they ask who helped?”

“They won’t. They need water.”

The next day, the hauler was told he could collect the tankers. Money for the first trips had been found too.

He went to see for himself. The trucks stood in a row against the

far wall of a yard. One was new. Another was worn but had good tires. He crawled beneath it, inspected the tank, asked to have the valve opened, and listened to the engine for a long time.

The man handing over the keys waited.

“You’re not saying I’ll never have to pay for these?” the hauler asked.

“No. I’m saying you don’t have to pay today.”

That was much easier to understand. He walked around the trucks once more and stopped beside the one nearest the gate.

“Can I take this now?”

“Yes.”

“And the others tomorrow?”

“That’s what they’re here for.”

That evening he recalculated the delivery charge. Without having to recover the whole sum on the very first trip, it came out quite differently.

Across the border, the new letter arrived on the day people were about to give up on some of their crops for good.

Delivery would cost less. Not so little that they would not feel it, but little enough to pay. More importantly, the hauler no longer demanded everything before the first load.

The people around the table checked the figures in turn. One calculated the cost of a full tanker. Another worked out how much each plot would get. A third asked what would happen if the first load was delayed.

“Then we lose another day,” said the man holding the letter.

“And if it never comes?”

He put the letter beside an empty mug.

“Then we’ll have as much water as we have now.”

Next came an argument about who should get water first. Everyone agreed it should go to those in greatest need, and

everyone could explain in detail why their own land needed it more than their neighbor’s.

Eventually they made a list and nailed it to a board beside the reservoir. The number beside the first name had to be corrected: someone had included the path between the beds in the size of his plot.

The woman with the pottery shard came to read the list that evening. She found her house and ran a finger along the line to make sure.

Her husband stood beside her.

“I’ll finish clearing the ditch.”

This time she did not ask why.

The first tanker arrived later than promised. Leaving the rainy country, the driver had spent a long time explaining that he really was carrying water and that there was nothing suspicious about it. The people checking his papers could not understand why anyone would buy abroad what ran off their own roofs.

Then the barrier rose.

At the reservoir, the driver found so many people waiting that he thought he ought to have brought a celebration as well.

He turned off the engine. The talking stopped.

“Where do you want it?”

They pointed. Then they pointed again from somewhere else, because the first man had been standing exactly where the truck needed to turn. The driver backed up slowly and stopped.

When they opened the valve, the water came in spurts, mixed with air. Someone said in alarm that it was about to run out again. Then the flow steadied.

The woman crouched beside the ditch. The water approached her fingers more slowly than she wanted. It stopped at a ridge, went around a stone, soaked into the dry earth. Her husband silently took his shovel and adjusted the edge.

The water went on.

The boy ran beside it. At the bend he stopped, looked back, and suddenly laughed. Nothing funny had happened. Water was simply going where water ought to go.

The driver let him hold the empty end of the disconnected hose. The boy held it with great dignity while the grown-ups argued about who had a suitable rag to wipe the coupling.

They could not save everything. Some stalks never rose again. In one plot, watering merely made it clearer how bare the ground was. But where life remained, the leaves began to open out by evening.

The second truck came the next morning.

The woman lifted her pottery shard. The little hole was dark with moisture.

She showed her husband, then covered it again, though there was no longer any need to check.

Meanwhile, the water at the warehouse had fallen. The workers stopped moving sacks and began drying the floor. The owner measured down from the lowest mark and told the hauler he had finally thought of something useful.

The hauler wanted to say he had thought of it long ago. Instead he

asked when he could collect the next load.

A short message was placed on Brown's desk: deliveries had begun, the trucks were running, the first water had arrived.

"So it worked," he said.

Antonio nodded.

Brown looked at the page again. He liked this news. Not its scale, not the sum involved, not the possibility of someone learning he had helped. Simply that sacks were no longer drowning on one side, while crops had stopped dying on the other.

"Keep it going," he said, and set the paper aside.

There were no thanks on it.

That day, he was not looking for them.

In the margins: 19 · 20

9. The Neighbor

The king heard about the water over breakfast.

The messenger began a long way from the point: the weather, the road, the number of trucks at the border. The king had time to break off some bread, butter it, and eat half before understanding that his neighbor was no longer facing famine.

“You should have started with that.”

The messenger bowed.

“Not all the crops have recovered. But they bring water every day.”

“Good.”

The king finished his bread. It really was good news. When a neighbor had a famine, things grew unsettled along your own border too. People began moving toward food. Along with them came rumors, grievances, and people who knew how to profit from misfortune. The king preferred his neighbor to stay on his own land, attending to his own troubles.

Now there was one less problem.

“Who’s helping?”

“They bring the water from where there’s too much of it.”

“I didn’t ask where they get the water.”

The messenger fell silent.

Until recently he had thought it was the same question. Some people had dry ground, others wet; some sold, others bought. But the talk along the road was no longer only about tankers.

“They say Brown.”

The king put down his knife.

“Which Brown?”

The messenger glanced cautiously at the adviser by the window.

“That Brown.”

“The puppeteer?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

The king looked at his bread for a while.

“Did he perform there?”

“I don’t know.”

“Was he seen?”

“Not that I heard.”

“Then where did his name come from?”

The messenger began explaining what people on the road had heard from people who had spoken to other people. It sounded convincing until anyone asked for the first person’s name.

The king stopped him.

“Did you meet anyone yourself? Anyone who was actually there?”

“There when the water came, yes. With Brown, no.”

The adviser turned a little from the window.

“There’s a great deal of talk about him.”

“I know what they say. Yesterday I was told he’d bought half the world. The day before, all of it. I’d like to know who owns my breakfast.”

The adviser smiled. The messenger tried to as well, though he was not sure he had permission.

The king picked up his knife, looked at it, and put it down again.

“You may go. If you learn anything besides roadside gossip, report it.”

The door closed.

For a while they could hear dishes being moved in the next room.

“Do you believe it?” the king asked.

“Which part?”

“That it’s him.”

The adviser took his time. He had served long enough to distinguish a question about facts from one requiring a useful answer.

“I don’t know, Your Majesty.”

“Can you find out?”

“I can ask our neighbor.”

The king looked up.

“Ask if a puppeteer gave him water while I sat at home?”

“Ask how they arranged it.”

“Would he tell us?”

“If he wanted to.”

The king pushed away his plate.

That was what he disliked: if he wanted to.

Not long ago, his neighbor had been sending requests for help. Dignified requests, but requests all the same. The king had taken his time answering. He needed to think, consult, establish how serious things were. Besides,

people usually remembered a favor better if they had been made to wait for it.

Now there was no need to answer at all.

His neighbor had managed without him.

“We should be pleased,” the adviser said.

“I am pleased.”

“They’ll have a harvest.”

“I heard.”

“We could send our congratulations.”

“Send them.”

The adviser bowed but stayed where he was.

The king tapped a finger on the tablecloth.

“But what if it really is Brown?”

“Then he’s done a good thing.”

“And what about the next thing?”

The adviser said nothing.

“Water today,” the king continued. “Something else tomorrow. Perhaps they’ll suddenly have everything we lack. And each time I’ll send my congratulations.”

“We can make arrangements with them.”

“We could do that before.”

The king looked out at his garden. It was watered in the morning, before the heat. The paths had dried by now, while beneath the trees the earth remained dark and damp.

He had never taken much interest in how much water that required.

“What if it’s true?”

The adviser did not answer at once. Not because he failed to understand the question. Because, after those words, no one needed proof anymore.

The king rose.

They went into another room, where they kept gifts too

important to give to the servants and too awkward to put anywhere else. A carved chair stood unused. Above it hung a painting given by a man convinced the king liked ships. Nearby, in a small frame, lay a card bearing Tom Brown's signature.

The puppeteer had left it after a performance.

The king remembered that evening well. There had been only a handful of guests. Brown had shown them something so funny that the king forgot to watch his own expression.

One small gesture had been particularly good. The puppet

prepared to bow, but first had to adjust an imaginary crown. She adjusted it at length, checked both sides, seemed ready at last—and discovered it still did not sit right. Eventually the person she meant to bow to had time to leave.

The king had recognized a neighbor immediately.

Everyone else seemed to recognize him too. At any rate, they laughed together most enthusiastically.

Brown had not named a single name.

Afterward, the king asked whether anyone else had seen it.

“This?” Brown said. “No. This is just for you.”

The king had been pleased.

Now he stood before the card, trying to remember who had laughed first.

“He’s performed for the others too.”

“Of course.”

“Do you know what he showed them?”

“No.”

“Do they know what he showed us?”

The adviser shook his head.

“We haven’t told anyone.”

The king picked up the frame, turned it toward the light, and put it back. His fingerprint remained on the glass.

“So nobody knows anything.”

The adviser wanted to point out that they did know a few things: water was arriving, crops were reviving, people were no longer buying bread made from the last sack of grain. But the king had moved on.

“And everyone pretends they do.”

He returned to the table and asked for paper.

The first invitation was ordinary. Thanks for the earlier evening, a few pleasant phrases, an offer to

visit again. The king listened to it and asked:

“What if he refuses?”

“He may.”

“Then we must offer more.”

The adviser added a fee.

The king thought.

“That’s not it.”

He took the pen himself but did not write. Several times he touched its point to the edge of the page, leaving tiny black dots.

“Make sure he understands we’d welcome more than a performance.”

“What else?”

“His advice. His friendship. Does that need explaining?”

The adviser tried to find the words. They sounded either too grand or too much like a request for help.

The king liked neither.

In the end they kept a simple sentence: “We would be especially glad to welcome you as our guest.”

“There,” said the king. “Perfectly clear.”

He signed the letter.

At the door, the adviser turned back.

“Shall I send congratulations to our neighbor as well?”

The king looked toward the second letter, which had not yet been written.

“Yes. Only don’t ask about Brown.”

“Why not?”

“I don’t want him thinking I’m interested.”

The adviser bowed.

After he left, the king returned to the card and carefully wiped his fingerprint off the glass.

In the margins: 21 · 22

10. A Place for the Bicycle

The woman moved the table to the window, then moved it back.

There was more light by the window, but a draft came through when she aired the room. She rested a hand on the edge, imagined school notebooks lying there, and moved the table again, just a little this time.

The second bed was already against the wall.

Before it arrived, the room had seemed small but quite comfortable. Now she discovered that she had to keep thinking not only about where she would

walk, but where someone else would walk. She could not leave the basin behind the door. She could not put a chair where someone would have to squeeze sideways to reach his bed. She could not fill the only spare drawer with things she had “nowhere else to put for now.”

She emptied the drawer.

Then opened it again to check that there was really nothing left.

The boy’s photograph lay on the table. He was looking slightly away from the camera. One shoe was untied. From the beginning, she kept noticing that lace and catching herself in the foolish

wish to bend down to the photograph and tie it.

She had first seen his picture among others. She read where he came from, how old he was, what he liked doing. Went back to the photograph. Then read it again.

She lived alone. She had a job, a small apartment, and a habit of cooking a little too much rice in the evening. The rest kept until morning.

That was not a sufficient reason to take in a child, and she knew it perfectly well.

So at first she made no phone calls.

For several days she simply walked through the apartment, noticing things she had never noticed. A second table could go by the window. There was a place under the stairs where people kept bicycles. The school was close. The market sold fish; if the boy disliked fish, she could cook something else. There was enough water. The roof did not leak.

Then she realized she was no longer arguing with the possibility, but with her own fear.

She called.

After that she had to tell people a great deal about herself. Show them the apartment, explain

what she lived on, answer questions no good book alone could prepare her for. She did not resent it. They were not entrusting her with an object she could return if it did not suit the room.

She asked questions too.

What did the boy eat? How did he fall asleep? What frightened him? What had he been told about her? Did he understand that moving was not a short trip?

Not everything could be answered immediately. Sometimes the answer began, “We’ll find out.”

In her experience, those words had often meant returning a

week later to remind someone what she had asked. Here, they really did get back to her.

Once she sent a document, and the next day someone called to say it had arrived and everything was in order. She kept the phone to her ear for a while, expecting to hear what was missing.

Now there was only the wait to meet him.

She had found the apartment long before the photograph. An advertisement had caught her eye by chance. The rent was unexpectedly low, and the landlord did not press her to decide at once. When she said she

needed until morning to think, he replied:

“Think about it.”

That had surprised her. Good offers usually disappeared before she could establish whether they really were good.

In the morning, the apartment was still waiting.

She moved in, hung curtains, and gradually stopped thinking of it as luck. That was how a home worked: one day it was simply the place where you kept your spoons.

Now she was counting the spoons.

She had enough things for one person. Things for two somehow required more care. Was that cup too small? Did the blanket look childish to a boy who already wanted to be grown-up? Should she buy slippers now, or should they choose them together?

She decided they would choose together.

The caseworker she had come to know during the wait came with a confirmed arrival date. They sat at the table between the photograph and a stack of clean linen.

“It doesn’t have to be perfect,” the caseworker said.

“I’m not trying to make it perfect.”

The caseworker looked at the empty drawer, which the woman had opened and closed for the third time.

“Just leave room for him.”

The woman took her hand off the handle.

She reached the airport far too early.

First she walked between the window and the arrivals board. Then she sat down. Then she worried she might miss something important by sitting, and stood up again. In her bag was a small packet of food chosen

after much thought. Now it seemed she had chosen the wrong thing.

The time on the board changed.

She went closer, although she could see the letters perfectly well.

Meanwhile, the plane was landing.

The boy had a window seat. He had been given a wide chair, a meal of his own, and people who kept asking whether he was comfortable. He said yes to one question without quite understanding it, and another blanket appeared.

He folded it neatly on his lap.

Outside, the ground had first been distant, like a picture, then suddenly became real. Roads appeared, little cars and roofs. The boy tried to choose the roof he would live under, but the plane turned and all the roofs went the other way.

After landing, he was not left to find his way alone. The person traveling with him carried a folder and told him where to go. The boy carried his own backpack. When offered help, he shook his head.

It was not heavy. It was simply his.

The woman saw them before they saw her.

She recognized his face at once, and at once understood how little the photograph had told her. A picture could not show how he held his shoulders when tired, how he turned at an unfamiliar voice, how tightly he gripped the strap of his backpack.

She said his name.

The boy stopped.

She had learned his name well. The rest of her prepared sentence, less well. He listened and answered so quickly that she understood nothing.

They looked at each other.

Then she smiled and admitted she had not understood. His

escort helped translate. The boy repeated himself more slowly.

He wanted to know if it was a long drive.

The woman nearly cried with relief. There was a simple answer to that.

“Not far.”

She pointed as though home were just beyond the airport doors. He looked that way and smiled too.

She remembered the packet of food once they were in the car. He took one piece, then another. So perhaps she had not chosen entirely wrong.

He looked out the window all the way.

She wanted to explain what everything was, but noticed he was tired and stopped. Only when their street appeared did she lean a little forward.

“Here.”

A truck stood outside the building.

At first she thought someone was moving. Then she saw a bicycle by the entrance and several boxes bearing her name.

The boy noticed the bicycle too.

“Is that yours?” his escort asked her.

“I don’t know.”

A man came out carrying a sheet of paper.

He recognized her, checked the apartment number, and said everything had been brought for the child's arrival: a bicycle, books, a computer. Food as well. The document said there was nothing to pay, either for the things or for delivery.

She took the paper and could not immediately work out where to look. First she checked the address. It was right. Then the number of boxes.

"All this is for us?"

"All of it."

"Our apartment is small."

“It’ll fit.”

He sounded so certain that she wanted to go upstairs and check they had not mistaken the floor after all.

She went up first and opened the door.

Upstairs, it turned out the delivery men already knew which boxes could be stacked and which would fit sideways through the narrow doorway. They asked permission to move a small cabinet and immediately suggested a place where it would not block the way.

She agreed.

The computer went on the table. The books went on the empty shelf beside it. The men took small packages out of the large boxes and arranged them on shelves and in spare spaces beneath the cabinet. Essentials stayed within reach; no one would have to get past a sack of grain to find the salt.

The woman crouched and opened a carton.

Rice.

Another held food she knew how to cook too. The supplies would last a long time. A very long time, provided she did not try to feed the whole building at once.

She turned to the man with the paper.

“Who should I thank?”

He looked at the top line.

There was a name there that meant nothing to her.

“You can write here.”

She picked up a pen, meaning to write at once. Just then, the boy cautiously touched the bicycle bell. It rang so loudly that everyone turned.

He took his hand away.

“It’s all right,” she said.

He did not understand the words, but he understood her face.

One of the men showed him how to ring it more softly.

When they had finished, the woman signed, thanked them again, and saw them to the door. The boy's escort was leaving too. He gave her a number to call with any questions, then crouched beside the boy and explained something.

The boy nodded.

The door closed.

The apartment became very quiet.

For a few moments she did not know what to do with her hands. While other people had been there, things had happened

almost by themselves: greet, show, sign, move. Now there were only the two of them.

She looked at the bed she had made ready.

“This is your place,” she said slowly.

She pointed to the bed, then to the empty drawer.

The boy took off his backpack, opened it, and took out a small object she did not have time to see properly. He put it in the drawer, then pushed the drawer almost shut, leaving a narrow gap.

She did not look inside.

The bicycle stood where the delivery men had left it. It really was in no one's way. There seemed to have been exactly the right amount of space waiting for it.

She pointed to the bicycle, then to him.

He nodded cautiously.

"Ride?" she asked.

He shook his head.

She sat on the edge of her own bed, embarrassed. Somehow she had assumed that, given a present like that, a child would want to go outside immediately.

He was quiet for a moment, then pointed to his stomach.

She jumped up.

That was what she should have thought of first.

She warmed some food and set two cups on the table. The boy helped carry the second, though she almost took it away for fear he would drop it. She stopped herself.

He set it down carefully.

Over the meal they misunderstood each other several times. Once she handed him the salt instead of a spoon. He looked at the salt, then at his empty hand, and laughed. She laughed too.

It was a little easier after that.

In the evening they did go down to the courtyard. Not to ride, just to look. He walked beside her, sometimes running a few steps ahead, then stopping to wait. Under the stairs he noticed a long recess and pointed.

“The bicycle?” she asked.

He nodded.

She explained with gestures that he could keep it there, but they would need a lock. They would buy one tomorrow.

He looked at the recess again. He liked having found the place himself.

When they went back upstairs, she moved the bicycle from the

wall where the delivery men had fitted it so precisely, and put it nearer the door. It could stay there for now. Tomorrow they would decide.

Tom Brown knew the dimensions of that apartment.

He knew how much space remained by the wall, how wide a table would fit beside the window, how many boxes could go beneath the kitchen shelf. He had already attended to many things the woman had not yet begun to worry about.

Brown did not know the bicycle would be moved on its first evening.

That day, it would not have spoiled his pleasure.

After the boy went to bed, the woman sat at the kitchen table to write her thanks. She listed the gifts, then crossed out the opening. It sounded as though she were confirming receipt of a shipment.

She began again.

She wrote that they had arrived safely. That the boy liked the bell. That, because of this help, she would not have to worry about so many ordinary things just now.

Then she stopped. A quiet voice came from the other room.

She put down the pen and went to the doorway.

The boy was sitting on the bed. He wanted to ask something for which they did not yet have a shared word. She sat beside him and listened.

The letter of thanks remained unfinished on the table.

In the margins: 23 · 24 · 25 · 26 · 27 · 28

11. Whose Name?

For a while, the brief reports were enough for Brown.

The water had arrived.

The trucks were running.

The child had made the journey safely.

He read them differently from letters about his performances. There was always something insufficiently respectful about an invitation: an ordinary greeting, words in the wrong order, a signature so large that its owner plainly considered himself the important one. There was nothing to find fault with in a

short report about water. It said what had happened.

Brown asked for details.

“Did they save all the crops?”

“Not all,” Antonio replied.

“Why not?”

“Some had died before the trucks arrived.”

Brown frowned.

He disliked solutions that came in time for some people but not for everyone. Yet as he read on—how much land had been watered, where the leaves were beginning to uncurl, how the next deliveries had been arranged—he grew calmer.

“Next year, we must start earlier,” he would say.

Antonio wrote it down.

There were more details about the child, though they did not all fit the order Brown understood.

He asked whether the bicycle was the right size. The answer came back that it was, but the boy had not ridden it on the first evening: he was tired and hungry.

Brown reread that line.

“Well, of course,” he said.

And asked them to stop bothering the woman with questions about the delivery.

The things had arrived. Now the two of them needed to get on with living.

He found that thought pleasant, too. He set the letter aside and, for a little while, asked nothing of Antonio.

Then another invitation arrived for a private performance.

Then another.

Requests were easier. They made it quite clear who needed whom.

One day Antonio brought a small newspaper from the region that had suffered the drought. It had been folded in four and was a little worn from the journey.

On the front page was a photograph of a truck beside the reservoir. People crowded around it. One held the end of a hose; another pointed to where the water should go. A boy was looking not at the camera but at the place where water had finally reached the ditch.

Brown studied the photograph for a long time.

He liked the fact that no one had made the people line up. They were busy with the thing they had come for.

Beneath the picture were thanks to the drivers and to the people selling water across the border. The article described how the

order of deliveries had been agreed on, how many trips had been made, and whose late-planted crops had been saved.

The hauler was called the man who had found a way.

It was not untrue. He had found the route, obtained the trucks, brought people together, and been the first to cross the border.

Brown read the article again.

Then he turned the page.

On the back were more news stories, advertisements, and a short letter from someone thanking his neighbor for repairing a gate.

There was nothing more about the water.

“Is that all?” Brown asked.

“Yes, sir.”

Thinking his employer wanted to know what happened next, Antonio offered to find out whether another issue had appeared.

“No need,” Brown said too quickly.

His assistant remained standing.

“Have they got something wrong?”

Brown looked at the photograph.

“No. It’s all correct.”

He put the newspaper on the desk beside the letters about his performances.

One envelope bore his name. In very beautiful lettering.

A few days later, the woman's thank-you letter arrived.

She apologized for not writing sooner. During their first evenings together, she and the boy had been getting used to each other. Then it turned out that he wanted to see the school before classes began. They had gone there, peered through the fence, talked about why the door was still locked, and agreed to come back another day.

He liked the bicycle. Especially the bell. For now, they looked through the books together, even when they could not understand everything without a translation. The woman wrote that the help had relieved her of worries she had been afraid to put into words.

“Thank you all,” she had written at the end.

Her name was underneath.

Brown read the last line and smiled.

Then his eyes returned to the word “all.”

He did not read the letter again. He asked Antonio to file it with the other reports.

Antonio took the sheet carefully by the edge so as not to crease it.

“A lovely letter,” he said.

“Yes.”

“They’re happy.”

“I’ve read it.”

His assistant fell silent.

Brown noticed how sharp he had sounded and was surprised. There was nothing in the letter to be angry about. The woman was grateful. The child was settling in. Everything had happened as he intended.

He dismissed Antonio and remained alone.

On the map hanging on the wall, borders still divided the land into different colors. Money, water, and trucks passed from one color to another. People made agreements, argued, and sometimes helped each other without his involvement. He could change a great deal, but he was absent from most of the changes.

He had arranged it that way himself.

This detail brought him no comfort.

Brown went to the window. In the street, a woman was trying to

hold a door open while someone carried a long board inside. The man thanked her without stopping his backward shuffle. She let go of the door and walked on.

A few seconds, and it was over.

Nobody wrote a letter. Nobody called for witnesses or established who really ought to be thanked. Help and gratitude had met in the same doorway.

Brown looked at his hands.

He could put his name to it.

Simply tell people to put it where there had been other signatures, impersonal labels, or nothing at

all. Let them thank him in particular.

But gratitude would bring questions. Requests. Complaints from those he had not helped. He would have to explain why the water had come here and not there, why this child had a bicycle while another had no shoes.

He liked arranging things so that everything seemed to happen by itself.

He wanted everyone to know who had made it happen.

For a while, the two wishes sat comfortably side by side, neither noticing the other.

Brown returned to his desk.

In a letter from a king, he was described as the only man capable of working such a miracle. He read that sentence twice. Then he picked up the next letter and compared the greetings.

That evening, Antonio found him still at it.

“Shall I prepare any replies for tomorrow?”

Brown pointed to one invitation.

“They promise a great deal.”

“Yes.”

“And understand very little.”

Antonio reread the letter.

“What don’t they understand?”

Brown was silent for a moment.

“They think I’m a conjurer.”

His assistant did not reply at once.

“They’ve seen your performances.”

“Exactly.”

Brown pushed the letter away as if it had failed to carry out an instruction.

Antonio gathered the remaining envelopes. The small newspaper with the photograph of the water lay at the edge of the desk. He was about to put that away, too, but Brown laid a hand on it.

“Leave it.”

Later, when everyone had gone, it began to rain.

Drops traced uneven paths down the glass. For a moment the sun appeared between the clouds, and the bush below the window shone as though someone had decorated it for a particular person’s arrival.

Brown watched it for a long time.

He remembered how it worked: a little rain, then light from the right direction. The drop must not have time to dry. The person must arrive just as it hangs at the edge of the petal.

Once, he had thought a gift like that could not possibly be misunderstood.

The girl had stopped beside the roses.

He had waited around the corner.

She had said, “What a beautiful day.”

And walked on.

12. The Gap

Once, Brown had not yet known that his name was Brown.

He had been a little black dot on a sheet of paper where you could travel a long way in one direction, then in another, without ever coming upon anything like up.

In those days, many things seemed settled for good. There was a distance between one mark of ink and the next. You could not pass through a thick stripe of ink. If someone went away, you could see where they went.

But the paper was uneven.

In one place the ink had parted, leaving a narrow gap. The black dot discovered it while trying to see what lay beyond the dark stripe. At first there was only another small piece of the world. Then something moved.

Another dot was there.

She approached a certain spot, stopped, and disappeared.

The black dot froze beside the gap.

There was no one there now.

It could not be said that she had gone away: to go away, she would have had to cross at least some small, visible distance. Nothing of the kind had happened. One

moment she was there, and then she was not.

The black dot waited.

The other dot reappeared.

In the same place—or almost. After a return like that, it was difficult to judge how much the “almost” mattered.

She seemed dissatisfied. She moved a little, stopped again, and began muttering.

Words came through the gap.

“Up. Down.”

The black dot examined the available world.

Up where?

The black dot tried the word on the space to one side, then on the space to the other. Nothing new came of it. Those directions already had names.

Beyond the gap, the space emptied again.

This time the black dot did not draw back, but waited where the return would be visible.

When the other dot reappeared, she tried again at once.

It did not always work. Sometimes she stayed where she was, and the black dot could not tell whether she was making an attempt or simply resting. Sometimes she vanished for only a moment. Sometimes she was

gone so long that it began to seem she would never return.

At such moments, the gap grew narrower.

The black dot pressed closer, although there was no closer left to get. It would have widened the crack if it could. But beyond the thick ink there was still someone else's piece of the world, and things happened there that could not be seen from here.

Then the other dot returned, and waiting became easy again.

"Up," she said.

A pause.

"Down."

The black dot no longer tried to replace those words with familiar directions. There was something they described, and now it had to be seen.

Once, it seemed that she had noticed the black dot beside the gap. The watcher drew back, then regretted it immediately. Something important might happen while the gap was unattended.

The black dot returned.

She continued her experiments.

Not for an audience. The black dot understood that: she was not waiting for approval, did not glance around after a successful disappearance, did not demand

to be admired. She herself needed to find out what would happen next.

And yet there was nowhere the black dot wanted to be more than near her.

There were other places to go, places where everything stayed where it belonged. No waiting there, no fear that someone might not return. But a step away from the gap was enough to make it impossible to stop wondering what was happening beyond the ink.

The black dot took up the familiar place again.

The black dot did not yet call it love.

There was only this certainty: to leave now would mean missing more than another disappearance. It would mean missing her.

Then the wind came.

The same wind reached both sides of the stripe. It did not go around the barrier or ask for a passage. It lifted the dot who practiced and the dot who watched.

The black dot saw the place where it had been.

The gap was there. So was the stripe of ink. But now the whole stripe was visible, and the space beyond it did not end at the

narrow opening through which it had been watched.

For the first time, the word “up” fit what was happening.

For the first time, there was somewhere for “down” to be.

The other dot was close by.

There was no ink between them now. To see her, there was no need to press against a crack and wait for her to reach the right spot.

She was here.

And around her lay a world the black dot could never have imagined while remaining on the paper.

Much later came faces, hands, streets, and schoolroom windows. The black dot came to be called Tom Brown. The dot he had watched became a girl who went on asking questions.

Brown could not always remember what he had thought beside the gap. The memory returned in another form: a narrow crack, waiting, a place suddenly empty, and joy when she reappeared.

He had fallen in love with her when she discovered up.

It had not yet occurred to him that a discovery should belong to whoever happened to be watching.

In the margins: 29 · 30

13. Weather After School

Brown left the first flower on a low wall the girl passed on her way home from school.

He had chosen the spot in advance. There was sunlight on the wall, the corner of a house kept off the wind, and a crack between two stones would hold the stem. The flower stood upright, as though it had grown out of the masonry.

Brown stepped back and looked.

It looked odd. Nothing like that ought to grow out of stone.

He pulled out the stem and laid it across the wall instead. Now the flower looked forgotten.

That was better.

Brown hid around the corner.

The girl was not alone when she came. Another schoolgirl walked beside her; they were talking and nearly passed straight by. Brown almost called out.

Then the girl noticed the flower.

She stopped, picked it up, and looked at the empty street beyond the wall.

“Someone’s dropped it,” her companion said.

The girl ran a finger along the stem. Then she put the flower back on the stones, more carefully this time, so that it would not fall.

“They might come back.”

They went away.

Brown stood around the corner for a long time. Then he emerged, took the flower, and carried it off in one hand, dangling below his knee.

He had not worked out how to show her that she was allowed to take the gift.

Leaving a note would be easy enough. But then he would have to decide what to write. “For you”

did not say who: anyone might find the flower. “From me” required a signature. A signature meant that the next day she would come up and say something, and he was not sure he would be able to answer.

He wanted to see her happy first. Only then would he step around the corner.

Roses should work differently.

There was a rosebush beside the road. The girl passed it almost every day. If it bloomed, nobody would look for the person who had lost the flowers. She would not have to pick them up, explain them to her friend, or leave them for an unknown owner.

Brown knew a little everyday magic.

Enough to coax a small bud open before the others. Not at once. You had to wait, watch, resist pulling at a petal. If you hurried, the flower looked as though it had not quite unfolded after sleep.

He spoiled the first bud.

Brown hid it behind the leaves and started on the next.

When that one opened, he simply stood looking at it for a while. The rose was small, but real. Its petals did not need to be held in place. If he stopped looking, the flower did not disappear.

Brown walked around the bush.

It was beautiful from the other side, too.

Now he had to wait for her.

The girl came later than usual, carrying an open notebook in front of her. She walked slowly, sometimes stopping to reread the same line.

She stopped beside the bush.

Brown straightened up behind a tree.

She glanced at the flower, smiled, and looked down at her notebook again. Then she closed it and walked on.

He had seen the smile.

It was the smile he had wanted.

But he had missed his chance to step out from behind the tree. Or rather, he had not: the road was clear, and she was walking slowly. He even took a step.

Then stopped.

If she turned around of her own accord, he would know what to say.

She did not turn around.

The next day Brown thought of rain.

Not a proper, lingering rain that soaked books in their bags and left mud on shoes. A brief, fine rain, as though the sky had decided to give the street a quick

wipe. It must end just as the school doors opened.

Brown checked the sunlight beforehand.

In the morning it fell on the other side of the bush. After school, the rays came between the houses and struck the roses directly. Leave drops on the petals, and the light would catch in them. The girl would see it from far down the street.

He thought about it all through class.

The teacher called his name twice. Brown stood and gave an answer that had nothing to do with the question.

The girl turned toward him. She did not laugh. She waited, as though she expected him to correct himself.

For some reason that was harder than if she had laughed.

After the bell, she went to the teacher with a question. Everyone else was packing their books, but she stood beside the desk, pointing to something in her notebook.

Brown lingered by the door.

“What if you started reading somewhere else?” she asked.

The teacher bent over the page. Brown did not hear the answer. He was watching the window:

outside, the sky was darkening exactly as it should.

If she stayed much longer, it would all happen without her.

He left.

Beside the bush, the air smelled of dust and warm leaves. The first drops hit the ground too heavily. Brown tried to make them finer. The rain slackened, almost stopped, then began again.

His sleeve got wet at the elbow while he checked the lower branches. He did not notice at once. A large leaf sheltered one of the roses; he had to draw it aside carefully. He held it while drops settled on the petals, then let go.

Now the sun.

The cloud would not move as quickly as he expected. Brown clenched his teeth and tried again. A gap opened between the gray edges. A strip of light appeared on the opposite wall.

A little more.

People began coming through the school gates.

Brown glanced over and nearly lost the opening in the clouds. He had to attend to the cloud again. By the time he finally saw the drops flash, the girl was turning into the street.

He stepped back around the corner.

This time she was not reading.

She came to the bush, stopped, and looked at it silently for a while. Then she held her palm beneath a rose. A drop slipped from a petal and landed on her fingers.

The girl laughed.

Brown was very close. From around the corner he could see her hand, the edge of her sleeve, and the sunlit half of her face.

“What a beautiful day,” she said.

Brown smiled.

Now he could step out.

He did.

She noticed him and nodded as you nod to someone you know when you meet them after school.

“Look,” she said. “It’s all shining.”

He looked at his own work.

“I see.”

“It’s a shame it won’t stay like that.”

He almost said he could make it happen again. That it was not so difficult for him, provided he knew the time, where to stand, and which leaf was blocking the light.

Instead he said, “It might.”

The girl smiled and gently touched a wet leaf.

“No. It’ll dry.”

He did not like her certainty.

“What if it doesn’t?”

She looked at him with interest.

“Then I’d want to know why.”

Here was a chance.

Brown knew what to say. Three short words: “I did that.” After that, he would no longer have to wait for her to guess.

But he imagined her asking why. Or how. Or not believing him at once and asking him to do it again.

Or perhaps she would simply say thank you and walk on.

“Your sleeve’s wet,” the girl observed.

He tucked his elbow behind his back.

“The rain.”

“I thought you’d left before it started.”

“I didn’t.”

She pressed her notebook to her chest while moving her books to the other hand. One began slipping, and Brown caught its lower edge.

“Could you hold these a minute?”

He took the books.

As she adjusted the strap of her bag, he noticed a title that meant

nothing to him. The book was old, its corners worn smooth. A folded sheet stuck out between the pages.

“Why do you need so many?”

“There’s something I need to look up.”

“In which one?”

“I don’t know yet.”

Brown gave a little laugh.

“Then why take them all?”

She considered this for a moment, as though it were a useful question.

“How else will I find out which one to look in?”

He had no answer.

The girl took back her books.

“Thanks. Are you coming?”

“Where?”

“I’m going to the library.”

Brown glanced at the bush. More sun was coming through, and the drops were already shrinking. If he left, no one would see how long he could keep the light like this.

“I’m going the other way.”

“See you tomorrow, then.”

She left.

He remained beside the roses, watching her as far as the corner.

He could have walked to the library with her. He thought of that only after she had disappeared behind the house.

Brown touched his wet sleeve. The skin beneath it had grown cold. Across the street, someone shut a window, changing the shape of the light it reflected onto the wall.

The girl had been happy.

She had smiled at him, asked him to hold her books, and thanked him.

Yet Brown kept returning to what she had said about the day.

A beautiful day.

As though it had happened all by itself.

He looked at the roses and tried to preserve a few more drops.

Meanwhile, the sunlight moved on along the wall.

In the margins: 31 · 32

14. Two Readers

The new boy was given a seat near the window.

He took a long time arranging his things on the desk. There were not many books. One corner of his notebook was folded over and would not lie flat. He smoothed it with his palm, then put a book on top.

His clothes were too large. The elbows had worn through and been mended with a different thread. Brown noticed that before he remembered the boy's face.

Probably his brother's old clothes.

The boy took out a pencil, checked its point, and began to listen.

Brown turned toward the teacher, too. But now and then he glanced back at the newcomer. The boy did nothing remarkable. He could not make rain or bring flowers into bloom ahead of their time. At least, there was no sign that he could.

During the break, the girl came over to his desk.

She asked something about a book. The boy opened it, turned a few pages, and showed her a passage. They bent over it together.

Brown watched her listening.

At first he thought she was about to explain something the newcomer had not understood. The girl often explained things, not to show how much she knew but because she could not leave a question half answered. This time, though, both of them were talking. The boy pointed to one line, she to another. Then she borrowed his pencil and wrote something on a separate sheet.

The bell rang.

They did not return to their places at once.

Brown decided it meant nothing.

A few days later he saw the boy outside the library.

The boy stood on the steps, searching his bag. He pulled out a notebook, put it back, and checked his pocket. Then he found a folded piece of paper, smoothed it out, and read it.

Brown recognized the handwriting before he could make out the words.

The girl's letters leaned a little. Sometimes she wrote too quickly and joined two of them as though there were not enough room for them to stand apart.

The boy put the note away and went inside.

Brown stood at the foot of the steps.

Then he climbed them, too.

The library smelled of dust, glue, and slightly damp clothes. A cloth lay by the door: visitors were asked to wipe their feet. Brown wiped his very thoroughly, to give himself a reason not to go straight in.

The girl sat at a table by the window.

Two books lay open before her. Paper strips stuck out of one; she held the other down with an elbow to keep it from closing. The newcomer sat opposite her and laid the note beside the books.

The girl read what he had written on the back.

She smiled.

Brown could not hear what she said. It was awkward to go any farther. There was too much empty space between him and their table.

He turned toward a shelf.

He took the first book that came to hand and studied its spine, though he was already holding it. He ought to open it. He did.

The page was full of numbers.

He did not want to read them.

At the table, a quiet argument was in progress.

“But it repeats here,” the boy said.

“I saw.”

“So maybe it isn’t a word.”

The girl pushed her notebook toward him.

“What about here?”

The boy fell silent.

Brown liked the fact that the newcomer did not know the answer. He turned a page and waited for the argument to end.

But the girl did not draw away. She took a pencil, circled something, and laid it between them. The boy bent over the notebook again.

They were busy.

Brown knew that her father was a sailor. He knew the books and

notes were not just for school. She hoped to understand a message, find her way to a telescope, work out something that might help her father. When she talked about it, one answer never settled the questions: there was more work waiting beyond it.

Brown had once thought that, sooner or later, she would bring that work to him.

He could do a great deal for her.

But she was sitting opposite a boy in someone else's ill-fitting clothes, studying a pencil circle on a sheet of paper with him.

Brown put his book back.

Not quite where it belonged: the neighboring spines were a different color. He noticed, but did not correct it.

The boy looked up.

“Hi.”

Brown nodded.

The girl turned around.

“Did you come for a book, too?”

“I’ve already looked.”

“Did you find it?”

“Yes.”

He did not know what else to say to make it clear that he had not come to stand between the shelves. They plainly expected an

answer, but he could find none that suited.

The girl moved her bag off an empty chair.

“You can sit here if you like.”

Brown looked at the chair.

Sitting down would put him beside them, not before them. He would have to ask what they were doing, admit he did not know what the argument was about, and listen to the new boy explain.

“I have to go,” he said.

He left before they could offer him anything else.

Outside it was dry. Without drops on them, the roses looked too ordinary.

Brown picked a blade of grass and drew it along a wet stone by the drain. Then he threw it away. He tried to remember what had made the girl laugh at the note. What could the boy write on half a scrap of paper that he could not do?

That evening he planned new weather.

It would begin a little earlier and last longer. Not just a bush by the road—the whole strip beneath the library windows. Leaves, wet branches, a bright wall reflected in a puddle. If the girl raised her

head from her book, she would have to look outside.

Brown arranged everything the next day.

The rain fell exactly when it was needed. Small drops remained on the outside windowsills. One hung above a crack in the stone for a long time without falling. Brown watched it as though it were the last important detail.

The girl was already inside.

The newcomer had not arrived.

Brown stood by the steps. He could go in, sit in yesterday's empty chair, and wait for her to notice the light. This time he was

not going to hide around a corner.

The boy appeared from the direction of the school.

He was walking quickly, a book tucked against his side. He saw Brown and stopped.

“Is she here yet?”

It was a simple question. Brown had just been looking at her through the window. He could say yes, and they would both go in. He could say nothing and climb the steps.

He said, “No.”

The boy looked at the door.

“Did she leave a note?”

“I didn’t see one.”

That, too, would have been easy to put right. Brown could say he had made a mistake, that he had only just noticed her by the window. But the boy was already opening his book and checking the slip of paper inside.

“I thought we’d agreed on today,” he said.

Brown shrugged.

He wanted the boy to leave. Not forever; nothing much would happen if he simply came back later. But now—to leave.

The boy put the note away.

“I have to return this anyway.”

He walked past Brown and opened the door.

Brown stayed beside the steps.

Through the window he saw the girl look up. The boy came to the table, put down his book, and said something. The girl looked toward the door.

Brown quickly turned away.

He heard footsteps behind him.

“She’s in there,” the boy said.

“I didn’t notice.”

The boy was silent for a moment.

“You can see her from here.”

Brown shrugged again, more sharply this time.

“Am I supposed to keep track of everyone?”

The boy went back into the library.

There was no quarrel. Nobody tried to find out why Brown had said it. Somehow that made it particularly unpleasant.

He moved over to the wall and stared at his shoes. A wet petal had stuck to one of them. He shook his foot, but it would not come off. He had to bend down.

Behind the glass, the girl was laughing.

Not at him. He could see the boy showing her something in a book. She held a hand to her mouth,

trying not to make a noise in the library. Then she took back the pencil and began writing again.

Brown straightened up.

Outside the window, the drops he had prepared still shone. He had spent time, held the rain just so, drawn the cloud away. A bright wall lay reflected in a puddle. Seen from the right spot, the whole street looked washed and new.

No one in the library was looking at the street.

Brown stepped closer to the window.

He could knock.

He could go inside.

He could bring the cloud back, put out the light, and send real rain over the town. Then they would at least have to close the little window above them.

He could already feel how easy it would be to spoil what he had worked so hard to arrange.

The girl looked up. For a moment, their eyes met.

She did not smile. She did not turn away angrily. She simply looked as though she wanted to ask something, but there was glass between them.

Brown looked away first.

He did not call the rain.

As he left, he paused on the steps and listened. It was quiet inside. He could hear pages turning and the librarian moving returned books.

He imagined sitting at that table now, if only he had not said yesterday that he had to go.

Then he imagined the newcomer looking up and asking why he had lied.

Brown went down the steps.

Years later, it was easier to remember it differently.

The girl had never noticed him. Other boys had laughed. Nobody wanted good deeds. He had tried

everything he could, but no one had loved him.

That version left no room for the empty chair from which she had moved her bag for him. No room for a simple question at the door, or for his own short answer.

But the roses remained.

Brown remembered every drop he had prepared for her.

And less and less of what she had actually said to him.

In the margins: 33 · 34

15. A Free Evening

By the time Antonio came in, the rain had stopped.

Brown stood by the window. A single drop remained on the glass. It held its place for a long time, then slowly slid downward under its own weight.

“Is that everything for today?” Brown asked.

“Not quite.”

Antonio had brought two letters.

One was an invitation to perform. The other concerned a man who intended to start a war.

Brown read the second.

The plan was set out in detail, with the thoroughness usually devoted to remodeling an inconvenient warehouse. First, the ruler would obtain what no one wished to sell him openly. Then he would make a terrible weapon and use it against his neighbor. The land thus vacated would be settled by his own subjects.

The author of the plan understood that the land would be poisoned.

He had even given the matter a separate section. People would live and work there until, in time, the danger diminished. Those who could not endure it would die. Others would take their

places. From a distance, on a map, it would all look like the gradual development of new territory.

Brown finished reading and laid the letter facedown.

“Do they know?” he asked.

“Who?”

“The people he’s going to send there.”

Antonio shook his head.

Brown picked up the first letter. For a while he stared at its elegant greeting without reading it.

“Don’t answer this yet.”

The young man arrived a few days later.

He had once left that country. Now he intended to return. He remembered its streets, its songs, the words people used to argue in the marketplace. Some of the words had changed; he noticed them in letters from home and asked what they meant now.

Brown did not show him a map. He pushed across the very sheet on which people had been turned into a means of developing land.

The young man read in silence.

“Can you persuade them not to do it?” Brown asked.

He looked up.

“Who?”

“The people planning it.”

“Him, I can’t.”

“And the others?”

The young man looked at the letter again.

“The others aren’t planning anything. They don’t know.”

Brown leaned back in his chair.

“Then explain.”

“This isn’t a performance, Mr. Brown. They won’t buy tickets and listen just because I’ve started talking.”

Brown frowned.

He disliked being reminded of the difference between an audience and the world. Lately the distinction had seemed less and less important.

The young man continued.

“And I can’t promise they’ll agree after the first conversation. Some will be frightened. Others will say it isn’t true. Some know, but hope it won’t affect them.”

“How much time do you need?”

“I don’t know.”

“Money?”

That question had an answer.

Brown listened. He asked what the money would be spent on.

The young man named travel, somewhere to live, a way of printing what was usually passed on in whispers. Not many things. But each had to be ready before people accustomed to being refused began asking for them.

Brown called Antonio.

“Arrange it,” he said.

His assistant made a note.

“And find out who promised to sell him what he needs for the weapon,” Brown added. “I don’t care for that purchase.”

The young man left soon afterward.

At first, his letters contained nothing that looked like success.

In one place, hardly anyone came. In another, people came but left before he had finished. Somewhere he was asked to speak more quietly. Somewhere else, not to begin at all: everyone had children; there was no need to make things worse.

Brown read and grew angry.

“I told you he knew how to talk to people.”

“He warned us it would take time,” Antonio reminded him.

“I remember.”

Brown remembered reluctantly.

Then something different appeared in a letter.

People had begun coming not merely to listen. One brought a paper of his own; another asked the young man to explain to a neighbor what he had been unable to explain himself. A short speech became a long conversation. The young man could not stop just because he was tired: there were still questions.

He wrote that this was a good sign.

Brown read the sentence again.

He would not have liked an audience to ask so many questions after a performance instead of applauding. Yet here,

for some reason, that was what worked.

At some point the ruler discovered that his future settlers were discussing why they should die on someone else's land. Not alone, not only around kitchen tables. A simple word, "we," had entered their conversations, where it had not been heard before.

Nor did the materials for the weapon arrive. The man who had promised to obtain them lost his old confident tone and began pushing back the delivery date. Finally, he admitted it could not be done.

The plan had to be postponed.

This did not make the ruler kind. It did not undo all he had already done. But the war he was preparing did not begin.

People had another day in which they were not required to die for his map.

Brown received a short report.

He sat for a while with his palm on the letter. Then he ordered someone to check that the young man had reached safety.

“He isn’t leaving yet,” Antonio said.

“Why not?”

“He says the conversation isn’t finished.”

Brown was about to object that the assignment had been completed. Then he looked at the original plan lying facedown and said nothing.

He had helped.

After that, people got on with their own lives.

That evening, for the first time in a long while, he did not feel like performing.

It was an unfamiliar feeling. A free evening had once meant an evening without pay. Now money could arrive without a stage, while the stage still required him to go out, hold the control bar, listen to other people laugh, and

pretend to be surprised when it all went wonderfully again.

Antonio asked how to answer the invitation set aside several days before.

Brown did not immediately remember it.

“Where is it from?”

His assistant named the place.

“A long way.”

“Yes.”

“Tell them I can’t just now.”

“Shall I suggest another date?”

Brown thought.

“When I’m in their hemisphere, we’ll discuss it.”

Antonio looked up to check whether those were the exact words he should send.

“Put it more gently,” Brown allowed.

The reply went out.

In time, a new letter arrived. They now offered to pay for the whole journey, send anything he needed, and let him choose any date and any length of performance.

Brown read it slowly.

Refusal, it turned out, did not end the conversation. It changed it in a pleasant direction.

“I’d like some sleep,” he said.

Antonio suggested replying to that effect without mentioning sleep.

Brown laughed.

Then they promised him a palace in which no one would disturb his rest.

Much the same thing happened with another invitation. First they asked him to come. Then they asked him at least to consider it. Then they wanted to know what might help him make up his mind.

Brown grew accustomed to refusing for reasons other than distance.

Sometimes he wanted to find out how much harder they would ask the second time.

He stopped giving ordinary performances. Now and then he agreed to a special evening. He deliberated for a long time, then might answer unexpectedly quickly because he was bored that day or liked the sound of the food they had promised.

The puppet heard the words changing outside the box.

First they had talked about work. Then about success. Now about who could be made to wait.

She still performed whenever Brown stepped into the light.

Moving grew easier. Understanding exactly whom each successful act was saving grew harder.

One day Antonio brought another invitation and stopped in the doorway.

“They seem to have run out of things to offer.”

Brown held out his hand.

“Then they’ll have to think some more.”

He read the letter, laid it beside the others, and looked at the calendar.

There were many free evenings ahead.

In the margins: 35 · 36

16. What the Neighbor Saw

At one of the last performances, the king scarcely laughed.

Brown did not notice at first. The king watched attentively, never looked away, and did not talk to the servants. An artist could usually make do with less. But this attention was unpleasant: it was the look you gave someone who was about to name a price and kept failing to begin.

The puppet was trying to get through a door.

There was no door, but its edge was unmistakable. She held it to let someone go ahead. Then she

changed her mind, stepped forward herself, stopped, and offered to let the other person through again. The more polite she became, the harder it was for anyone to get anywhere.

One of the men standing by the wall could not help snorting.

The king raised a hand. The man immediately pretended it had been a cough.

Brown thought the act had failed and pulled the puppet toward the other end of the light. She went with him, but at the last moment held the invisible door from that side instead.

The man by the wall bit his lip.

The king leaned forward.

When the performance ended, he asked Brown to come closer.

“Were you trying to tell me something?”

Brown looked at him.

“When?”

“With the door.”

“Didn’t you like it?”

“On the contrary. Very much. I’d like to understand it more precisely.”

The king picked up his glass but did not drink.

“She could have gone through herself,” he said. “Nobody was stopping her.”

Brown nodded.

“But she kept waiting for the other person.”

“You were watching closely.”

“So one should stop waiting?”

Brown was already tiring of the conversation.

He wanted his gift, his gloves off, and a drink in a room where no one would ask what every movement meant. Admitting that he did not know all the movements in advance was, of course, out of the question. Besides, someone who had paid

that much generally expected a more pleasing answer.

“Sometimes,” Brown said.

The king nodded as though that was exactly what he had needed.

“I understand.”

Brown decided not to interfere.

The next day, when he was reminded of the date on which the fair was due to open, the king remembered this advice. He ordered it opened a week early. His neighbor had been counting on the traders reaching his fair first, as they had agreed.

The traders chose the fair that was already open. The neighbor was surprised.

Then he learned that Brown had performed there the night before.

He saw Brown's will behind the king's decision, though Brown knew nothing about the fair.

By the time the kings met, each had prepared several questions he did not wish to ask directly.

At the table they talked of the journey, the weather, and how difficult it had become to find a suitable evening to meet. One remarked that he was far too busy. Another replied that he understood: everyone had things to do. Both glanced at the man who had recently entertained Brown.

“Enjoy yourselves?” his neighbor finally asked.

“Very much.”

“They say he hardly sees anyone these days.”

“Then we were fortunate.”

An entirely innocent answer. The king delivered it with the particular ease that requires considerable effort.

“And what did he show you?”

The recent host remembered the door. He wanted to describe the act, if only to find out whether the others understood it as he had. But that would mean admitting that the advice he had acted on

might well have been an ordinary joke on a stage.

“Something he doesn’t usually show,” he replied.

His neighbor smiled.

“Of course.”

A servant brought another dish. For a few minutes everyone attended to their plates.

Then the king sitting opposite said, “He’s very good at that. At first you think it’s all just for laughs. Then you realize what it’s for.”

He was not speaking of the door. He was remembering quite another performance, one that had led him to pay closer

attention to a neighbor. But nobody knew that.

The first king looked up.

“Yes. Exactly.”

The neighbor who had asked about the performance decided the two men meant the same thing.

For the rest of dinner he contributed little. He listened.

If anyone called Brown merely a conjurer, the first two smiled. If anyone said he was praised too highly, they did not argue. This silence was far more troubling than an argument.

On the way home, the king asked his adviser, “Did you notice?”

“Notice what?”

“They know something.”

His adviser spent the journey trying to establish just what his master had noticed. By the time they arrived, he, too, had begun to wonder whether he had missed something important.

In another kingdom, the impression left by the performance had been quite different.

Brown had appeared there earlier, before people began talking about the water. His host had laughed at a puppet unable to decide whose hand to shake first. Afterward, he had told the

artist that he understood people wonderfully well.

Brown had thanked him.

Nothing else had happened at the time.

Now the king tried to remember whether that grateful bow had contained a hint. He thought Brown's eyes had lingered on someone present. Or perhaps they had not. Enough time had passed to let memory choose.

He asked them to find the man who had stood closest to the stage that evening.

The man was brought in. Assuming that something valuable had gone missing, he

immediately began explaining that he had touched nothing after the performance.

“That isn’t what I’m asking,” said the king. “Did Brown say anything before he went on?”

The man thought.

“He asked for the light to be adjusted.”

“What else?”

“For people not to walk near the stage.”

The king waited.

“And for some water, Your Majesty.”

The king sat up.

“Water?”

“As a chaser.”

The servant was dismissed.

Nothing had been discovered. Yet the question of water continued to seem important to the king for some time, although he knew they had been talking about a glass of it.

Meanwhile, Brown’s invitations grew stranger.

Once, people had asked when it would suit him to come. Now they explained at length who else had managed to visit them, what rooms they could offer, how highly they valued friendship,

and how little they believed in rumors.

They wrote about rumors at particular length.

But among the stories was one thing several people had seen with their own eyes: water had risen in an empty glass while the pitcher stood far away. The man with the tray repeated exactly that. He did not say the artist could fill rivers or cure the sick. When asked such questions, he answered that he had held the tray and seen the glass.

By the time the story reached the other courts, the tray had all but been forgotten.

The king by the window listened to it twice. The second time, he asked whether the water had been cold. The storyteller thought this a very sensible question; he did not know that beyond the bedroom wall, for the third night running, they were changing the wet cloth on a girl's forehead.

The gray-haired king, who had seen the glass himself, now tried to remember how long the water had taken to fill it. In his hand he held a report that smelled of smoke. The paper was clean; the smell came from the sleeves of the man who had brought it.

Neither had heard Brown promise to help. Each had supplied the rest himself.

Antonio sorted the letters and tried not to mix up the replies. One invitation asked him to tell no one about the visit. Another, on the contrary, gave permission in advance to announce that Brown would be doing them the honor. A third left him to decide whether anything ought to be said.

“Do they want a performance or not?” his assistant asked.

Brown reread the latest letter.

“They want me to come.”

“And to perform?”

“If I go, we’ll show them something.”

He said it without his old interest.

Performing no longer gave him as much pleasure as being able to refuse. When Brown went onstage, everything depended on the evening. When he did not, people imagined for themselves what they had lost.

“Don’t answer these people yet,” he said.

Antonio set the letter aside.

“And these?”

“Them either.”

His assistant looked at the two envelopes.

“They’ll write again.”

“Probably.”

They did.

News of refusals and unanswered letters traveled from king to king faster than accounts of the performances. Everyone knew very well whom Brown had not answered. Almost no one believed that he had left them all equally unanswered.

One thought his neighbor was concealing a visit.

Another thought his neighbor had obtained a promise and was keeping it to himself.

A third assured the others that he personally had no reason to hurry, then ordered another letter sent, this time without the usual seal on the outer envelope.

Brown had to show them no new miracles at all.

One day the king whose water troubles had long since been resolved received a very friendly message from a neighbor, inviting him to meet and talk without witnesses.

He ordered preparations for the journey, but before leaving he asked, “Will Brown be there?”

“There’s no mention of him.”

The king reread the letter.

“Precisely.”

Meanwhile, the neighbor who had sent the invitation was asking his own adviser almost the same thing. He wanted to know

whether his guest would bring the puppeteer along.

When they finally met, neither had brought Brown.

Both felt relief before realizing that the other felt it, too.

“Perhaps,” one said, “we should stop guessing?”

The other did not answer at once.

It was a sensible suggestion. He simply did not know what he would have to reveal in exchange for the other man’s candor.

In the margins: 37 · 38 · 39 · 40

17. All the Kings of the Whole World

This time they counted the armchairs before the meeting.

Seven identical ones were required.

They found six. The seventh differed only in the carving on its back, but that was precisely the trouble: the moment someone sat in it, the others would begin asking what the difference meant.

In the end they brought seven plain chairs.

These proved more comfortable than the armchairs, though no one mentioned it.

First they agreed that nobody was obliged to discuss his relationship with Brown. The proposal passed quickly: each feared that otherwise he would be required to do the discussing.

Then it emerged that this made conversation difficult to begin.

“Did he answer you?” one asked.

Another looked at him.

“We just agreed.”

“I’m not asking what he answered. I’m asking whether he answered.”

“That is also part of our relationship.”

Several kings nodded.

A third suggested that they should not waste time on what they had agreed not to discuss.

“We would all like to see him,” he said. “That is enough.”

One of the men near the window looked away. He disliked “all” when it included his own desire, but to object would be worse. He would have to explain why he had come.

“Suppose we do.”

“There’s no supposing about it. That is why we’re here.”

The king by the window picked up his cup.

His neighbor held his saucer between two fingers. Several times he had been about to speak, and each time had taken a drink instead.

At last he put his cup down.

“If we each go on inviting him separately, things will stay as they are.”

“And how are they?”

He looked around the table.

Nobody helped him answer.

“Each of us thinks someone else has done better.”

The room fell silent.

It was too simple a statement. To dispute it without revealing how accurately it had found its mark would be difficult.

“We should invite him together,” the king added.

“On whose land?”

“Wherever he likes.”

“And who will be the host?”

“All of us.”

The king by the window gave a short laugh.

“Splendid. Seven hosts and one guest. He’ll be very much at ease.”

But the objection no longer stopped the discussion. If Brown came to all seven at once, nobody

could claim to have seen the important part while the others were absent. At least, that was how those around the table imagined the evening.

One king asked whether a joint invitation meant that afterward none of them would invite Brown privately.

This time the silence lasted.

“We are discussing one evening,” another said at last.

The first nodded.

He disliked the answer, but he was not prepared to demand of the others a promise he would not make himself.

The servants left. Paper was placed on the table.

They began with “We invite you.”

It produced a letter of the kind Brown had received too many of already.

One king suggested “We eagerly await.”

“And he won’t come,” his neighbor observed. “And we shall go on awaiting.”

They turned the paper over.

Then they wrote “We would be grateful.”

This reassured everyone briefly. The phrase sounded dignified and demanded nothing

unpleasant of whoever said it. But the eastern king asked to hear the whole letter read aloud, then inquired, “What exactly would we be grateful for?”

“For his coming.”

“Then until he comes, we are offering him nothing.”

“We are offering a great deal,” someone objected.

The eastern king swept a hand above the table, as though to indicate that nothing was lacking here.

“He already has a great deal.”

One king tapped his cup.

“We can offer him more.”

“How much?”

He named a sum.

No one was surprised. Each had already offered something similar and now preferred not to recall the result.

“And if he won’t come for that?” asked the king by the window.

“We’ll increase it.”

“And then?”

The conversation stopped again.

The eastern king took a clean sheet and wrote a short phrase.

His nearest neighbor read it, leaned back, and looked at the writer as though he had proposed removing their crowns.

“No.”

They passed the sheet around.

On it were the words “We beg you.”

“We do not beg anyone,” said the king by the window.

“Not yet,” the eastern king replied.

“And we shall not.”

“Then we must find another way to explain that we really do want him to come.”

“He understands that already.”

“Of course. But until now, each of us wanted it alone.”

Several kings looked at the sheet again.

The eastern king did not try to persuade them that the words were pleasant. He merely suggested putting all seven signatures beneath them.

“None of us will be asking on behalf of the others,” he said. “None will stand beneath another.”

The king by the window shrugged.

“Only all of us beneath him.”

Nobody found an answer.

Outside the door, someone moved a tray. The servants were waiting to be called. Seven men

sat over a few short words and somehow could not decide whether those words actually changed what was already happening.

“It looks too pitiful on paper,” one finally said.

The others turned to him.

“What paper?” asked the eastern king.

He looked at the sheet, then at the pen beside it.

“We don’t have to send paper.”

Gold was proposed almost immediately.

Once they were talking about gold, things became easier. It was

a familiar language. Gold could be weighed, compared, ordered thicker. It did not apologize for taking up space.

“A card,” said one king. “The usual size.”

“Pure gold.”

“With our coats of arms.”

“And our seals.”

“There’ll be no room left for the words.”

They summoned a man who could make things so small that you wanted to look at them for a long time. He listened to their requirements and asked them to repeat the number of signatures.

“Seven.”

“Every one must be clearly visible,” the king by the window added.

The craftsman looked at the blank sheet.

“Visible to whom? The person holding the card, or the person facing him?”

No one had considered that visibility might involve such details.

“The person holding it,” the eastern king replied.

The craftsman drew an oval on the paper.

The signatures could run around the edge. Beside each there would be room for a coat of arms, a seal, and a flag. From a distance, a pattern. Up close, everything required.

“And whose signature will be at the top?” they asked.

The craftsman looked up.

“That is for you to decide.”

The kings looked at each other.

Eventually they decided to begin the pattern with a small ornament rather than a signature, arranging the signatures in a ring. Each king checked the position of his own.

Nobody wanted to be the one found last.

“And in color,” said the king who had earlier proposed the large sum.

The craftsman nodded.

Stones could supply the colors.

Everyone liked diamonds, too. With diamonds around it, the word “beg” no longer seemed quite so lonely.

While the craftsman prepared his first drawing, the kings returned to the wording.

They removed the lengthy forms of address. These took up space and, after the opening they had chosen, sounded as though the

writers were trying to hide behind their own eloquence.

What remained was:

“We beg you. Give one more performance.”

Underneath: “All the Kings of the Whole World.”

The king by the window read the lines twice.

“The whole world,” he repeated.

“Isn’t that so?”

He did not answer.

Now this was what he wanted Brown to see. Not seven separate requests to be put off one at a time, but seven rulers whom no

one had ever seen asking together.

The craftsman requested samples of their signatures.

The first king signed with a broad, practiced flourish. The second looked at it and asked whether the actual size would be preserved.

“Of course not,” the craftsman replied. “The shape.”

Then the second signed, too.

The others followed. One signed again because his first attempt seemed insufficiently confident. Another ordered a blot removed from the sample of his seal, although the craftsman had

already said he did not intend to reproduce the blot.

Nobody signed for anyone else.

When the last hand lifted from the paper, the eastern king called a servant and asked for fresh tea.

Suddenly, they all felt tired.

Then they discussed how to deliver the card. Brown might refuse an ordinary messenger. Sending it through his assistant would be too much like all the previous letters. They did not want to entrust it to any one king to hand over at a meeting, either.

“He must receive it himself,” said the king by the window.

They agreed.

They decided the valuable object must be protected from other hands. No one explained the protection in detail to all seven. It was enough for them to know that only Brown would be able to open it.

The craftsman gathered the drawing and the samples. At the door, he stopped to await final permission.

They could still change their minds.

The king who had first proposed inviting Brown together looked at the others.

“Do we all agree?”

Each answered for himself.

The craftsman bowed and left.

The chairs remained around the table. When the kings rose, one automatically looked for the chair he had occupied, though it no longer made any difference.

Nobody had been given a special place.

On that, they parted.

Brown stayed out a long time that night.

Before leaving, he had sorted through the puppets without deciding which one to lift. He left the box open on a low bench. The control bars lay across its rim, beside a glove he had taken off.

The puppet waited until the footsteps in the corridor stopped.

One lamp was burning. Its light did not reach the bottom of the box, but there was a round patch of it on the wall above. If she raised a hand, fingers appeared in the light.

She raised it.

Then lowered it.

She wanted to get out of the box. Not to be lifted higher still.

She pulled her control bar toward her. It turned, nudging the glove. She froze. Nobody came in from the corridor.

The glove lay palm up. One finger was tucked inside, and she had to

go around it before climbing over the rim. Her strings trailed loosely behind her. The bench was wider than the box. On the strip that remained, there was room for both feet.

She stood.

The wood underfoot was smooth, except for a long groove near the edge. She put one foot on either side of it and tried walking sideways.

On the third step, her foot slipped.

She sat down, holding on to the box. Her shoulder did not like having weight put on it. She had to wait before standing again.

Now she followed the groove. One foot after the other. Onstage, no one would have waited for her to walk so slowly. Here she could look down and place her foot again.

Something small lay at the end of the bench.

At first she missed it: it was the same color as the wood beneath it. A hand. Four fingers had been carved together, with the thumb a little to one side. A dark ring left by a sleeve still marked the wrist. A string led from it, back into the box.

She crouched.

She had been finding this loose hand for a long time. Sometimes

it was under her back. Sometimes it disappeared, and she would search for it, unable to turn over everything piled on top. Now it was outside. It must have fallen out while Brown was sorting through the puppets.

She reached for it.

The string at her wrist drew tight before her fingers could touch it.

She looked back. The control bar had caught against the box. She could go back, turn it, and drag it a little farther. But that would lay another string across the groove she had just learned to walk along.

She went back and moved the bar.

There was less of the groove left clear.

A floorboard creaked in the corridor.

She lay down beside the glove, stretching out along the rim of the box.

Antonio came in.

He held letters in one hand and a small sewing box in the other. He put the letters on the table, the sewing box beside the lamp, and sat down. For a while he did nothing. Then he took off his vest.

A side seam had come apart.

Antonio tried bringing the edges together with his fingers. They met. Pleased with this, he took a

needle from the sewing box and began to thread it.

The puppet watched the thread miss the eye again and again.

Antonio moved the lamp.

The circle shifted across the wall, and the shadows of the box and glove disappeared with it. Now the light fell on the table. The puppet turned her head. The wooden hand was still at the end of the bench.

At last Antonio threaded the needle.

He turned the vest inside out. Laid a broad strip of cloth against the seam, took it away, laid it there again. The strip was too

wide. He cut a narrow piece off it, placed the rest along the seam, and began sewing it on.

The puppet cautiously set a foot on the bench.

Antonio looked up.

She did not have time to draw it back.

He looked toward the box. Then at the glove. He got up and came over.

She lay without turning her head. A human hand stopped close to her face. The fingers opened, but took neither her nor the control bar.

A string hung over the edge of the bench.

Antonio followed it with his eyes all the way to the floor. He moved a nearby chair whose leg might trap the string if someone sat down.

“Not here as well,” he said quietly.

It was not clear whom he meant to tell.

He took the glove and returned to the table.

Now the puppet lay in full view. She could move. Antonio would probably see.

She watched his hands as he mended the vest. The needle went into one side of the cloth and came out the other. After

each stitch he drew the thread through, but before pulling it tight he smoothed the seam with his thumb. One stitch displeased him. He unpicked it and made it again.

The puppet stayed where she was.

Antonio tried on the vest and fastened the bottom button. He turned one way, then the other. The seam held.

He gathered up the needles. Looked for his thimble on the table and found it under the letters. The narrow scrap of cloth fell onto the bench. Antonio bent, picked it up, and laid it on the rim of the puppet box. In the light, a

thread showed clinging to one end. He pulled it off, rolled it between his fingers, and dropped it in the wastebasket.

Then he left with the letters.

The puppet listened to his footsteps. They went away, came back, went away again. Somewhere a cupboard opened.

She waited until that, too, was quiet.

The strip lay beside her knee.

One side was smooth; short threads stuck out on the other. She took it by a corner. The scrap was longer than her arm, but very light. She dragged it toward the wooden hand.

Before, she had needed both hands to carry it. Its thumb caught on her costume, and she was always afraid of dropping it somewhere she could not reach. Now she worked the cloth under its wrist. Lifting one corner, then another, she shifted the hand toward the middle.

It took several tries. The cloth slid away; the hand stayed where it was.

She pinned the edge with her knee.

This time it worked.

She walked backward toward the box. Every two steps she stopped, drew the cloth closer, and looked over her shoulder. The hand rode

along without turning over, trailing its string.

At the rim, she had to pick it up. The cloth caught on a splinter and stayed on the bench. She let it go. What mattered was not dropping the hand to the bottom.

She set it beside the empty sleeve.

The other puppet lay on his side. He had striped trousers, worn paint on his chin, and a short forearm ending in a break. She turned back the cuff and fitted the wrist against the broken end.

The pieces matched.

As soon as she took her fingers away, they parted.

She tried again. Held them longer. Waiting did not make the wood hold.

She sat beside him.

Antonio had left the sewing box on the table. But the table was far away, the needle was long, and she had not seen him put a single stitch through wood.

She looked at the empty sleeve again. It was wider than the arm. The cuff had lost its button long ago.

She went back for the scrap, freed it from the splinter, and returned. Wrapped the hand once. There was not enough cloth to go around again, but the thumb no longer stuck out. She tucked the

wrapped hand into the empty end of the sleeve, beyond the cuff.

She brought the string out at the side so it would not be trapped. Then she folded the cuff inward.

The hand disappeared.

Carefully, she lifted the other puppet's elbow and lowered it. The hand stayed inside the sleeve. The arm was not whole again. But its pieces were together, and the hand should no longer end up underneath everyone else.

The other puppet did not move.

She straightened one striped trouser leg and took her hand away.

The lamp was still burning. Nobody spoke in the room. Brown might not return for a long time. Or he might return very soon.

She climbed back onto the bench.

The control bar kept her from walking to the end. She moved it closer to the box, lifted the string out of the groove, and laid it alongside. There was room for three clear steps.

She took the first sideways. The second heel first. On the third she stopped and turned on one foot, steadying herself with a finger against the box.

It was not how she did it onstage.

She tried again.

This time she did not need to hold on.

The next morning Antonio brought a clean towel.

Wood dust remained on the bench. Antonio wiped the wood, turned the towel to a clean side, and wiped it again. He was nearly at the box.

The puppet lay beside her neighbor.

Antonio picked a piece of thread off the floor. Then another. He gathered the short, useless ends on the towel. There was no longer a hand on the bench to be picked up with them.

He stopped beside the open box. He took the edge of the lid but did not close it: a control bar was in the way. He moved the bar and noticed the turned-in cuff.

The puppet did not move.

Antonio reached in with a finger and straightened the striped trousers. His hand lingered over the empty end of the sleeve.

“What are you doing in there?” Brown called from the next room.

“Cleaning up.”

“We’ll need the things soon.”

Antonio withdrew his hand. He gathered the towel by its four corners so that nothing he had

collected would spill, and went out.

The puppet raised herself a little.

She drew the bundle to the very edge of the cuff. If she left it like that, the man would see what was inside. He would not have to search. She only had to wait until he opened the box again without being in a hurry to go somewhere else.

In the next room Brown was choosing a waistcoat. One seemed too tight, another not handsome enough. Antonio suggested the first, offering to leave its bottom button undone. Brown told him to bring a third.

The puppet looked at the hand.

One corner of the scrap of cloth had come loose. She tucked it in and pushed the bundle back. Not so far that she could not take it out again. She adjusted the cuff, carefully lifted her neighbor's arm, and let go.

The hand stayed with him.

That evening the box was opened behind another screen.

Brown sorted through the control bars without looking down. For a moment the puppet in striped trousers rose above the others. His empty sleeve swung. She began to reach after him, then stopped: the bundle had not fallen out.

“Not this one,” Brown said, lowering the bar.

She was lifted next.

In front of the light she had to soften an overlong step again. Then turn, pause, and fail to notice something the audience had already noticed. Someone laughed before the others. She waited for the rest.

The act went well.

Afterward Brown took his bow alone. She lay beside the box, listening to his applause, waiting only until she could climb over the edge.

Her neighbor’s leg had folded awkwardly beneath him. She

straightened it. Then she checked the cuff.

It was still holding.

In the margins: 41 · 42 · 43 · 44 · 45 · 46

18. Two Millimeters

The stranger passed so close that his sleeve brushed Brown's.

Brown stopped.

There was plenty of room in the street. He had time to think the man might at least apologize, but the stranger had already moved on, merging with several dark figures near the corner.

Brown looked around.

A window above the street closed. Outside the next house, someone was taking a long time to find the right key. Nothing worth his attention was happening.

He walked on and almost immediately felt his pocket pulling more heavily than usual.

He put a hand inside.

His wallet was still there. So was something else: soft on the outside, heavy within.

He took out a small leather case.

In the dim light he could not quite make out its color. But his fingers told him how finely the leather had been worked. It neither creaked nor creased, lying smoothly around the hidden object. A small stone glittered in the center.

Brown looked back toward the corner.

Only the man at the door remained. At last the key fit, and he went inside, pulling the door shut behind him.

Brown slipped the case back into his pocket.

He walked home faster.

Antonio was waiting with two letters. Brown raised a hand at once.

“Later.”

His assistant put the letters down.

“Shall I bring you anything?”

“Light.”

Antonio looked at the burning lamp, moved it closer to the desk, and stepped back.

Brown sat down. He took out the case and placed it before him.

There was no name or seal on the outside. He turned it this way and that, looking for a lid. He could not even find a seam. It was as though someone had stretched fine leather around an object and forgotten to leave a join.

“Was it given to you?” Antonio asked.

“Left in my pocket.”

His assistant hesitated.

“Do you know by whom?”

“No.”

Antonio examined the case more closely without touching it.

Brown held it up to the lamp.

The stone was a diamond. A small one, almost modest compared with those people had lately been sending him. It sat in the leather like a button for which someone had forgotten to make a buttonhole.

Brown pressed it.

Something pricked his finger.

He snatched his hand away and glared at the fingertip. A small drop appeared.

“What the—”

The case opened.

A tiny needle had read the DNA in the drop of blood and

identified the owner of the finger. The case had no wish to engage in conversation, check a signature, or believe someone who claimed to be Mr. Brown. It was meant to open for one person only.

Had anyone else pressed the stone, the leather, the diamond, and everything inside would have begun to melt. The precious object would have become a puddle of sludge for the next rain to wash away. No one would have had even a fragment left to show off as a find.

But these were the right hands.

Brown forgot his finger.

Inside lay a gold card.

He lifted it between two fingers, then laid it on his palm. The gold had a persuasive weight. Only two millimeters thick, the size of an ordinary business card. But no plain paper rectangle had ever made its own weight so unmistakable.

A pattern ran around the edge.

At first Brown took it for decoration and looked at the center.

“We beg you. Give one more performance.”

Below it:

“All the Kings of the Whole World.”

He did not call Antonio over immediately.

He read it again.

Brown had received many requests lately. People invited him, pleaded with him, assured him that a celebration would lose all meaning without him. Some even tried to take offense in advance, as though it were his duty to spare them the feeling.

None of that was here.

Here they begged.

He put on his pince-nez.

The pattern around the edge ceased to be a pattern. Tiny flourishes emerged. Each was familiar: Brown had seen these

signatures in letters, only much larger. Beside them were coats of arms, seals, and flags, their colors picked out in minute diamonds.

Brown tilted the card toward the lamp. Little sparks traveled from one edge to the other.

“Antonio.”

His assistant approached.

“Read it.”

Brown handed him the card. The case remained on the desk.

Antonio carefully held the gold by its edges. He read it silently, glanced at his employer, and, receiving no question, read it again.

“Aloud,” Brown said.

“‘We beg you. Give one more performance. All the Kings of the Whole World.’”

Antonio used the level voice in which he usually read letters.

Brown frowned.

“Did you notice who signed it?”

His assistant tilted the card.

“Seven of them.”

“Not how many. Who.”

Antonio looked at the coats of arms again.

“All of them, sir.”

Brown leaned back in his chair.

At last it sounded the way it was written.

He watched the little rectangle of gold in his assistant's hands. How often had these men kept him waiting, or kept someone waiting whom he had sent? Once, he had thought himself fortunate if a king was pleased and remembered to pay. Then the kings had begun to wait. Then to coax.

Now they had come together.

Inside one small pattern were men accustomed to others stepping aside, falling silent, changing their minds. One ordered a road opened, and it opened. Another ordered it

closed, and it closed. Across seven kingdoms there was room for someone to be carrying out their wishes every day.

Here they had written only a few words.

Every one was addressed to him.

“Did they try to send it through you?” Brown asked.

“Not this card.”

“Then they wanted me to receive it myself.”

Antonio nodded.

Brown took the card back. He ran his thumb over its smooth center, avoiding the stones. There was nowhere on the gold for any king

to hide behind another. Each had left his own signature.

“This hasn’t happened before, has it?” he asked.

“Nothing like this.”

His assistant was looking at the open case. On an ordinary evening he would have asked where to put such a valuable thing so that it would not be lost among the papers. Now it was clear that nothing should be put away yet.

“What shall we tell them?” he asked instead.

Brown did not answer.

The two earlier letters with which Antonio had met him at the door

lay on the desk. Brown pulled one closer, glanced at its seal, and pushed it away again. It now looked like a request written before people had understood how little they were asking for.

“They want a performance,” he said.

“Yes.”

“One more.”

“That’s what it says.”

Brown smiled to himself.

He could agree. They had not even named a day. They would wait until he chose. He could tell them to arrange it anywhere. Ask for anything that came into his head. Say he would go only to a

place he had never intended to visit.

He had performed for money.

For gifts, too.

He could take more land, but land meant thinking afterward about people, water, roads, and whoever would send a complaint. Today he wanted something simple.

He tilted the card toward the lamp again.

Seven signatures.

Brown counted them, as though he had not believed Antonio. He moved a finger from one coat of arms to the next. He paused at the last, not because that king was

special in any way. It simply happened to be the last coat of arms.

“Seven,” he said.

“Yes, sir.”

“I don’t much like seven.”

Antonio looked at him.

“The number?”

“Of course the number. What else?”

Brown set the card exactly in the middle of the desk. Then moved it a little closer to himself.

“Six is better.”

His assistant did not ask why. Brown had preferences he

disliked explaining: the color of a curtain, the distance to a chair, the time at which drinks should be brought.

But there were seven kings.

Antonio stood waiting.

Brown smiled.

“Bring me a clean sheet of paper.”

In the margins: 47 · 48

19. A Simple Condition

Antonio assumed they were discussing the seating.

Seven armchairs instead of six was no great difficulty. They could form a semicircle; there could be an aisle down the middle. But Brown liked everything arranged exactly as he wished, and Antonio was about to ask which seat should be removed.

Brown held the gold card before him.

Seven signatures wound around its edge. Each was tiny, and behind each lay lands, cities, roads, people who had never

seen their kings as close as he now saw their names.

“Six,” he repeated.

“We could ask them to choose who comes,” Antonio said.

Brown looked at him.

“They’ve chosen. They’re all coming.”

“Then who doesn’t come.”

“And where will he be?”

Antonio did not understand.

“At home, I imagine.”

“So there will still be seven.”

Brown covered a coat of arms with his finger.

Now only six were visible around the edge.

He moved his finger. Seven.

Covered it again.

Antonio stood opposite, watching another man's country disappear beneath the pad of a thumb.

"They can decide for themselves," Brown said. "Let them choose one."

"To be absent?"

"To be gone."

His assistant was silent for a moment.

"Altogether?"

Brown put the card down.

“All six will kill him. Then there’ll be the right number.”

He said it quietly. Nothing in the room changed. The desk remained a desk, a cart passed outside, someone in the next room set a cup on a saucer. Antonio heard that brief clink with particular clarity.

He wanted to ask again, though he already had.

“Are you joking?”

Brown looked at the golden invitation.

“They asked for a special performance.”

“They asked for a performance.”

“One more. You read it.”

Antonio nodded.

“I did.”

“Then they know whom they’re asking.”

Brown rose, walked across the room, and stopped at the window. For a moment Antonio thought that would be the end of it. Such things had happened before: his employer would devise a sharp reply, say it aloud, then allow a gentler one to be written.

The assistant carefully picked up a blank sheet.

“We could say you agree, provided the hall is specially prepared.”

Brown turned.

“Why?”

“To ensure the evening meets your wishes.”

“I’ve told you my wishes.”

Antonio put the sheet down again.

Brown returned to the desk and sat. For a while he studied the signatures, as though checking whether the writers took their own request seriously enough.

“They’ll divide the land,” he said. “Equally. So no one complains.”

“The people will still be there.”

“Of course. I’m not asking them to kill people.”

Antonio looked up.

Brown noticed the look but interpreted it in his own way.

“Just one,” he explained. “And I won’t be choosing.”

He drew the paper toward him.

The opening was exceedingly polite. Antonio heard several familiar expressions of gratitude and, for a second, almost believed the rest would return to its usual course.

Brown thanked them for the invitation.

Expressed his pleasure.

Announced that he was prepared to consider performing again.

Then his pen stopped.

“‘Upon fulfillment of the following conditions,’” he said.

Antonio did not sit down at once. The chair was there, but sitting felt strange: it would turn this, unmistakably, into work they were doing together.

Brown looked up.

“You aren’t going to stand all evening, are you?”

His assistant perched on the edge.

They both looked at the paper. Only one saw an interesting idea

that needed to be made clear. The other was still searching for somewhere to stop the sentence without saying aloud what would have to be said.

“A secret ballot,” Brown said. “More convenient. Let each decide whom he wants to keep. Whoever gets the fewest votes loses.”

“And if they don’t agree?”

“No performance.”

“That’s all?”

Brown looked surprised.

“What else? I’m not forcing anyone.”

Antonio glanced at the card. The word “beg” still shone.

Brown wrote down the condition and reread it. Something was missing. The murder might remain in the part of the evening that would be hurriedly cleared away, like a broken chair before the guests came in.

“They must have dinner,” he said.

Antonio did not answer.

“Together. So it can’t look as though one did it and the others had nothing to do with it.”

“You’ve already said all six must kill him.”

“Then they’ll go on together.”

He added another line.

Antonio read it when the pen left the paper.

Cook the dead man. Bring him to the table. Eat him.

His assistant looked away.

Brown watched him with something close to curiosity. Antonio could usually listen to the most unusual wishes and turn them into simple questions: how many people, when to deliver it, where to put it. Now there was no question to be found.

“The servants will cook,” Brown said. “They won’t have to stand in the kitchen themselves.”

Antonio slowly straightened.

“It isn’t about the kitchen.”

“I understand.”

Brown said this quickly, like someone who did not need the obvious explained. Then he bent over the sheet and changed a word to avoid repeating it.

Someone outside asked permission to come in.

Brown told them to wait.

He read the reply once more. There was no promise of eternal life. No chance to bring back the dead, deliver nations from misery, or put an end to war. None of the things the petitioners might hope to discuss with him after the performance. Those

hopes were not on the page; he was not responsible for them.

Once they had met the conditions, there would be a performance.

If Brown was satisfied.

“‘I may agree,’” he said, adding the qualification.

Antonio looked at the final line.

“Even after that—may?”

“If they do everything properly.”

Brown put down the pen.

For a few moments neither moved.

“They can refuse, though,” Antonio said.

It sounded different now. Not a question about procedure, but a hope he could not ask his employer to put to the test.

Brown picked up the gold card and ran a finger over the tiny signatures.

“They can.”

He sounded pleased.

Then he allowed the person waiting outside to enter.

“An envelope,” he said. “And sealing wax.”

Antonio rose, but Brown kept a hand on the sheet.

“This stays here for now.”

“You’ll think it over?”

“They’ll read it when they arrive.”

Brown folded the letter so that not a single line remained visible. He pressed his seal into the warm wax and waited for it to cool.

“Now send for the craftsman. I need seven cards. Transparent ones.”

Antonio looked at the gold invitation.

“Glass?”

“I have enough stones.”

The collection filled three shallow drawers in a cabinet. Each stone had its own compartment; a few still had notes beneath them bearing the donors’ names. Brown ordered everything

brought out. Antonio cleared the middle of the desk but left the sealed envelope where it was.

Brown laid the gold invitation beside the collection. Seven coats of arms ran around its edge. He turned the card, bringing each one toward him in turn.

For the gray-haired king, he found an emerald. A thin pale streak ran deep through the green. Brown held it up to the lamp.

“This one.”

He remembered the single chair in front of the screen. The king had asked how long the performance would last, as though time belonged to him too.

Afterwards, he had spent a long while examining the glass Brown had filled without a jug.

“Let him look some more,” Brown said, setting the emerald beside the coat of arms.

For the sick girl’s father, whose letters kept returning to water, he chose an aquamarine. Its blue was so pale that it almost disappeared at the edge.

“Perhaps he’ll finally see something in it besides my glass.”

Antonio wrote down who was to receive the stone.

An amethyst went beside the eastern king’s coat of arms. The purple deepened toward one end.

Brown turned the pale side toward himself, then the darker one.

“This one likes to begin a long way from the point. By the time he reaches his request, you’ve forgotten what he wants.”

He chose a part of the stone where the color was more even.

The king with the broad ring was to have pink tourmaline. Brown reached for a pale stone, then changed his mind.

“He won’t notice. Something brighter.”

He found one that stayed pink even in the shadow of his palm. He set it beside the next coat of

arms and looked for a moment to make sure his own finger was not hiding it.

For the quiet king, Brown took a piece of rock crystal.

“That will give him nothing to say about the color.”

The dark wood of the desk was visible through the clear stone. Brown moved it onto a clean sheet of paper. It looked better, though nothing in the crystal itself had changed.

He allotted pale golden topaz to the king in the dark coat. As Brown remembered him, the man could listen to an answer as though whoever gave it still had something to account for.

“Hardly any color,” Antonio said.

“Let him work out what I meant.”

For the gray-haired king’s younger brother, there was a choice of two yellow stones. Brown picked up a citrine, held it in his palm and put the other stone back in its compartment.

“This one watched the stage, not his neighbors.”

He sounded almost approving. Then he slid the citrine over to the others.

Seven stones lay beside seven coats of arms. When the craftsman arrived, he did not take the stones at once.

First he held each up to the lamp. He examined the emerald longer than the others, turning it so slowly that Brown had time to ask twice what was wrong.

“An inclusion,” the craftsman said, pointing to the pale streak. “I can’t cut here. I’ll take a plate from the other side.”

“I want them thin. Like a visiting card.”

Brown showed him the gold invitation.

“About two millimeters for the finished card?”

“Yes.”

“Where the stone won’t allow it, I’ll leave it thicker,” the craftsman

said. “They won’t bend. And they mustn’t be dropped.”

“They’re for kings.”

The craftsman looked at the stones again and asked for a separate case for each.

The next morning, Brown went down to the workshop.

Two flat blanks for one card had already been sawn from the aquamarine. The craftsman fixed one to a holder, brought it to the turning wheel and began to grind away a thin layer. Water ran over the stone. Blue-tinged slurry drained into a tray; each time he drew the holder back, the plate seemed a little lighter.

Brown reached for it.

“Not yet.”

The craftsman wiped the blank, checked its thickness in several places and fixed it back in place. One edge was thicker than the other. He had to grind that edge separately, with careful touches.

After grinding, the surface was still cloudy. Brown put Antonio’s written note beneath it: the letters blurred.

“You promised it would be transparent.”

“After polishing.”

Polishing required a different compound. The craftsman worked on both faces, then

smoothed the edges. When he laid the plate on the paper again, the recipient's name could be read through it. He worked more slowly on the emerald. On the topaz, he marked in advance the direction in which pressure must not be applied. None of the stones grew softer by growing thin.

The engraver brought seven small maps.

Each road began at a different palace, but all ended in the same place: the old salt wharf. Antonio checked the bridges and turns. The drawings showed very little of the sea beyond the estuary; no islands were marked.

“On the outside, the name and the date,” Brown said.

“And the wharf?”

Brown pointed to the two thin plates prepared for one card.

“Between them.”

The engraver held the sample up to the lamp once more.

On the inner face of the first plate, he cut fine lines for the shore and the road. He filled them with gold, removed the excess and let the craftsman check his work. Then the second plate of the same stone went on top. The craftsman joined them, carefully lining up the edges.

Brown picked up the finished aquamarine. He could see the white paper and the edge of the desk through it.

“Where?”

The craftsman turned his hand a little toward the lamp.

The golden road flashed inside the stone.

Brown straightened the card and saw the desk through it again. He tilted it. The road returned, reached the river and stopped at a tiny wharf.

He ran a fingernail over the surface. It was smooth; the map lay beneath the second layer, and

he could not catch a nail on any of its lines.

“Like that,” Brown said.

He repeated the movement, without help this time.

On the face, the engraver put only the king’s name and the appointed date. No address, no explanation of how to find the way. The personal inscriptions were checked against the names around the gold invitation; the seven stones were no longer moved from one place to another.

Antonio read the finished cards before they were laid in their separate cases.

“Aren’t we to tell them how to look?”

Brown raised the emerald. In direct light, only the name and date were visible. He turned his hand slightly, and a shoreline appeared beneath it.

“They want to see what other people can’t.”

His assistant said nothing.

Seven cards lay before him. The way to the wharf could be found on them. What awaited the guests after the journey was engraved neither outside nor within.

Brown’s seal was stamped on the cases. He ordered the invitations sent and put the sealed envelope

containing the conditions for the performance in the desk.

“They’ll read this when they arrive.”

In the margins: 49 · 50 · 51 · 52

Rehearsal for the Rain

An independent story lives in the margins.

> *The rain on the windowsill is better at this than I am. I've only thought of a beginning. It's finished already.*

Back to the story

> *I brought a box. The bottom goes tok, the lid goes tap. Please don't sit on the orchestra.*

Back to the story

> *Let's play by the window next time it rains. I'll hum and you can tap. Let me try my beginning first.*

Back to the story

I tried. I can fit three taps into your long oooo. When I add a fourth, you frown.

Back to the story

The fourth one is still inside my head. I don't know how to show you yet. I'll draw a circle.

Back to the story

Then my tap can be a square. Sing the circles, tap the squares. So far I can read our music.

Back to the story

I added an arrow: go back here. And here you go back again, but leave out the first circle.

Back to the story

I went back to the wrong place. Started at yesterday's jam stain. That has a little tail too.

Back to the story

I'll draw a line round the stain. Don't play that. Play this loop quickly, then slowly straight away.

Back to the story

By the time I've read "straight away," you're on the next line. Can I listen once without the paper?

Back to the story

All right. But don't come in before me after the long note. My

tune is still going round the corner there.

Back to the story

I tried ending with two quiet taps. My hands just did it that way. Did you hear?

Back to the story

I heard. It sounded as if you were making fun of my ending. I spent the whole of lunch on it.

Back to the story

I wasn't. I liked the bit where you stopped and two taps were left over. I wanted to show you.

Back to the story

You're showing me again while I'm talking. Give me the sheet. I'll rub out the squares near the end.

Back to the story

You're rubbing out a circle too. Wait, I'll hold the edge. The paper's getting really thin there.

Back to the story

Now there's a hole. I can see the table through it. I can't remember which arrow was under your finger.

Back to the story

Neither can I. My finger was holding the paper, not the tune. I'll put the box away for now.

Back to the story

It did rain yesterday. I sat by the window on my own. Without the box, the beginning felt too short.

Back to the story

I tapped on my knees at home. After the third tap I waited for your oooo. Then I remembered you were at your house.

Back to the story

Will you bring the box again? I won't try to mend the old sheet. I've got the back of an advert for potatoes.

Back to the story

I will. Let's play first and draw it afterwards. And please don't put a circle round the potatoes.

Back to the story

I tried your two taps. My last loop doesn't fit with them. I liked that loop.

Back to the story

I liked it too. But I keep waiting for it to end. Could we try your beginning again, without the loop?

Back to the story

Without it, I could hear your second tap. All right. I'll keep the loop on another sheet, for another tune.

Back to the story

I'll put the tin lid away. It clatters so much I can't hear

your beginning. It is a splendid clatter, though.

Back to the story

Don’t throw it out. Let me have one clatter too. There. Back to the box now.

Back to the story

The box sounds sleepy after the lid. I found a corner with a crisper tap. I’ll use that one.

Back to the story

I drew the beginning, then left a gap for the rain. After that come your two taps. Then I start again.

Back to the story

I nearly put a square in that space. Stopped myself. My hand keeps wanting to add one more.

Back to the story

I laughed in the middle of my long note. You looked at the potatoes as if they'd missed their cue.

Back to the story

They aren't paying attention at all. Let's try again. No need to rub out the laugh. It isn't on the sheet.

Back to the story

We've played it all the way through. Nobody went back to

the jam. But there hasn't been rain for three days.

Back to the story

I put two chairs by the window. One for the box, one for us to take turns on. The audience will have to stand.

Back to the story

What if nobody comes? I've already worked out how to tilt my head before we start.

Back to the story

Tilt it for me. I'll be right there. Then I'll nod to you. Don't start at the first nod, though. That's a practice nod.

Back to the story

Rain! Quick, get the box. I'll move the plant pot. It's taking up the spot where we were going to listen.

Back to the story

Got it. The rain got quieter while I was moving the chair. Shall we skip the practice nod?

Back to the story

We started. Right at the empty space, the rain stopped. I waited for a drop. A car went past instead.

Back to the story

I waited too. Held the box in both hands so I wouldn't tap by

mistake. We stopped in the middle of our tune.

Back to the story

Shall we start again when it rains? But I'm already here, and so are you. I want to finish now.

Back to the story

Let's carry on from there. I'll nod—a real one this time—hold up two fingers, then tap.

Back to the story

We finished. On the last note someone outside slammed a door. Its ending was louder than ours.

Back to the story

But the door hasn't got potatoes. I tried to clap, only the box was in the way. Thanks for holding it.

Back to the story

Now I've clapped for you. We took turns again. Good thing we had two listeners.

Back to the story

And both of them kept getting distracted by playing. Same tune tomorrow, or a different one?

Back to the story

The same one first. I want to remember the bit where we waited for the rain.

Back to the story

Just don’t add another arrow. I remember that bit. It’s where I hold the box in both hands.

Back to the story

I’ll leave a fresh side for the next tune. My loop could go here. Or something I don’t know how to hum yet.

Back to the story

I won’t bring the tin lid yet. I’ll wait and hear what you try. There’s another side of the box we haven’t used.

Back to the story

Leave this edge clear. Someone might sit down with us and need a bit of room too.

Back to the story

I’ve left it clear. The pencil’s here too. It’s quiet for now.

Back to the story

What will your music start with?